

Tools for the Dysregulated,
Tired & Trying

CPTSD Toolkit



Love, Bella & Wolf



Important

Disclaimer & Mental Health Support

This toolkit is not a substitute for therapy, diagnosis, or medical advice. It's a peer-created guide based on personal experience, compiled with care and supported by publicly available mental health resources.

If you are in crisis or need clinical support, please contact a qualified professional or local emergency services.

This is a companion, not a cure.

It's the voice of someone who's walked through the fog and found a few tools that helped them make sense of it all. You'll find suggestions, reflections, and grounding exercises - but no one-size-fits-all advice, and definitely no promises of instant healing.

Take what helps.
Leave what doesn't.
Adapt it to your truth.

If at any point this workbook brings up distressing memories or emotional discomfort - pause. Breathe. Reach out. You don't have to do it alone.

Crisis Support Contacts (UK-based)

Samaritans (24/7): 116 123
Shout (Textline): Text "SHOUT" to 85258
Mind Infoline: 0300 123 3393
NHS 111 or Emergency: 999 (UK)

This is the hand of a big sister - not a clinician.

There is no pressure to complete every section. Healing is not linear. Come back when you're ready.

You're not broken.
You're becoming.
And you're not doing it alone.

Love, Bella & Wolf

**For You -
The Dysregulated, Tired & Trying.**

The one who is still here.
This book is for the version of you that survived what you never should have had to.

For the part of you that kept going, even when it didn't make sense.

For the you that forgot how to feel safe, and the you that's starting to remember.

You were never broken.

You adapted.

And now, you get to reclaim what's yours.

Love, Bella & Wolf

My Journey

This isn't a textbook. It's lived experience.

I didn't create this toolkit because I figured everything out. I created it because I had to - because there was a time when I was drowning in symptoms I couldn't name:

The panic that came out of nowhere, the numbness I couldn't shake, the rage I turned inward, and the shame that coloured every interaction. I didn't know it was CPTSD (Complex Post Traumatic Stress Disorder). I just thought I was broken.

I spent years in survival mode - trying to be functional, useful, good - while quietly falling apart.

I've worked in frontline roles, in youth work and children's services, supporting people in crisis who I often related to far more than I let on.

I was the calm in chaos for others, even while I ignored the chaos in myself. At some point, I had to stop abandoning myself to keep showing up for everyone else.

Healing hasn't been linear. It's been jagged, messy, and at times, nearly unbearable. There were days I genuinely didn't think I'd make it through - where even getting out of bed felt like climbing a mountain. But I kept going - not because it got easier, but because stopping meant giving up. And I've spent too long being dismissed, unheard, or treated like a problem to shrink myself any further.

Through it all, there were only a few constants, Bella and Wolf - my dogs - that have been my anchor.

When everything else felt unsafe, they were the soft place to land. They aren't just pets. They are my calm in the chaos, my safety net.

**They are my cabin in the woods -
the glow of firelight behind rain-streaked windows in a dark forest.**

Love, Bella & Wolf

My Journey

They stayed beside me through sleepless nights and long, silent days. They nudged me to go outside when I was lost inside my own head.

Their steady, wordless presence has been a kind of therapy no human ever quite matched.

This guide - and everything I've poured into it - is the result of fighting for myself.

It's built on what I've learned about trauma, the nervous system, survival responses, and how healing isn't about "getting over it", but learning how to carry it differently.

I don't have all the answers. But I know this now: surviving wasn't weakness. It was resistance.

And Bella and Wolf were beside me the whole time - quietly reminding me I'm still here.

Still breathing. Still becoming.

I still dissociate. I still catch myself freezing, fawning, spacing out. But now I know what's happening - and that changes everything.

What helped me most wasn't a diagnosis or a method, it was learning how to be with myself again, not just in theory, but in practice.

Breathing through a flashback, speaking gently to the scared child inside me, listening to what my nervous system needed instead of overriding it.

This toolkit is made of the things that actually helped. The gritty, grounding strategies that kept me alive on the worst days. They're tools I've used with young people, colleagues, friends - and always come back to one question:

Would you speak to your 10-year-old self like that?

That pause?

That's where self-compassion begins.

This book isn't about healing perfectly.

It's about reclaiming the parts of you that never stopped trying.

And reminding you - especially on the hard days - that there is nothing wrong with the way you learned to survive. Let's rebuild. One page at a time.

Love, Bella & Wolf

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The Nervous System & Dysregulation

“Healing doesn’t mean the damage never existed. It means the damage no longer controls our lives.”

- Akshay Dubey

Your nervous system is your body’s constant guardian - scanning for threats and safety even when you’re not aware of it. It’s designed to keep you alive.

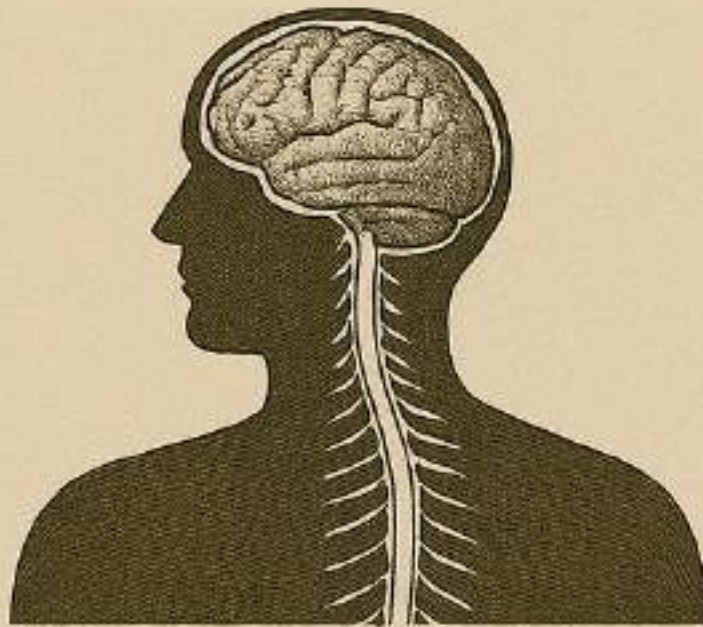
But trauma, especially when it’s chronic or complex, can throw your nervous system out of balance. It can get stuck in survival modes - fight, flight, freeze, or fawn - long after the danger has passed.

Understanding these responses isn’t about “fixing” something wrong with you. It’s about seeing what your body is doing beneath the surface, so you can meet yourself with awareness, kindness, and control.

This chapter will guide you through the basics of your Autonomic Nervous System, what survival responses look and feel like, the Window of Tolerance (your nervous system’s “safe zone”), and practical tools to help you expand safety and calm.

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The Autonomic Nervous System (ANS) The Basics



The Sympathetic Nervous System

- ◆ Prepares the body for action
- ◆ Increases heart rate
- ◆ Inhibits digestion
- ◆ Stimulates glucose release

The Parasympathetic Nervous System

- ◆ Calms the body and helps it rest
- ◆ Slows heart rate
- ◆ Stimulates digestion
- ◆ Promotes energy storage

The Autonomic Nervous System

The Autonomic Nervous System (ANS) is the part of your nervous system responsible for automatic functions - things your body does without you thinking about it.

That includes heart rate, breathing, digestion, and even how you respond to stress or danger.

It has two main branches:

The Sympathetic Nervous System (SNS) - “The Gas Pedal”

When your brain detects a threat, real or perceived, the sympathetic system kicks in. It’s responsible for activating the fight, flight, or freeze responses. Your body is flooded with stress hormones like adrenaline and cortisol to help you survive the moment.

In this state, you might experience:

- ◆ Rapid heartbeat
- ◆ Shallow breathing
- ◆ Muscle tension
- ◆ Dilated pupils
- ◆ A tingling sensation, similar to pins and needles
- ◆ Digestive slowdown (or upset stomach)

This is your body gearing up for action. It’s not always a conscious process - your system decides for you, in milliseconds how to respond. Think about survival, this is exactly what your body is designed to do - adrenaline is released from the adrenal gland which is located in the pancreas as a wake to help you survive whatever threat you are facing in that moment.

The Autonomic Nervous System

The Parasympathetic Nervous System (PNS) - “The Brake Pedal”

This branch is in charge of rest, recovery, and repair. It brings your system back into balance after the threat has passed.

In this state, you might experience:

- ◆ Slower, deeper breathing
- ◆ Relaxed muscles
- ◆ Steady heartbeat
- ◆ Digestion resuming normally
- ◆ A general sense of calm and safety

This is sometimes called the “rest and digest” state. It’s essential for healing and long-term wellbeing.

Trauma and Nervous System Dysregulation

For people with trauma histories, the ANS can become dysregulated - stuck in survival mode or flipping rapidly between states.

This means your body might respond to everyday stress as if it were a life-or-death situation, or struggle to return to a calm state even when you’re safe.

You might not feel in danger, but your body behaves as if you are.

That’s not your fault, it’s your nervous system doing what it learned to do in order to protect you.

The Survival Responses: Fight, Flight, Freeze & Fawn

The Survival Responses: Fight, Flight, Freeze, and Fawn

When the nervous system perceives a threat - real or imagined - it shifts into survival mode and this isn't a conscious choice; it's automatic. The body reacts based on how it has learned to survive. These responses were once adaptive, helping us escape danger, but they can become maladaptive when triggered repeatedly or unnecessarily in everyday situations.

Fight Response

The fight response prepares the body to confront the threat head-on, whether this can be physical or verbal. The nervous system floods the body with adrenaline to give a surge of energy and sharpened focus.

What it might look like:

- ◆ Raised voice or defensiveness during conflict
- ◆ A sense of injustice or need to be in control
- ◆ Feeling easily irritated, frustrated, or angry
- ◆ Tension in the jaw, fists, or chest

For some, "fight" becomes a default response to emotional discomfort - anger protects vulnerability.

Flight Response

The flight response drives us to escape - either literally or emotionally. The system gears up to run, to avoid the danger.

◆ What it might look like:

- ◆ Restlessness, anxiety, or constant busyness
- ◆ Difficulty staying present in relationships or conversations
- ◆ Avoidance of confrontation at all costs
- ◆ Perfectionism or overthinking as forms of control

Flight often shows up as chronic worry or an inability to relax. The body is ready to run even when there's nowhere to go.

The Survival Responses: Fight, Flight, Freeze & Fawn

Freeze Response

The freeze response immobilises the body. The nervous system slams on the brakes - you're still alert, but stuck. This can feel like a full-body pause.

What it might look like:

- ◆ Feeling paralysed or unable to speak in stressful situations
- ◆ Dissociation or emotional numbness
- ◆ Difficulty initiating tasks or making decisions
- ◆ "Shutting down" mentally or physically under pressure

Freeze can be deeply misunderstood - it's not laziness or indifference, but a nervous system locked in overwhelm.

Fawn Response

The fawn response is about appeasing perceived threats. It's often developed in environments where conflict felt dangerous and connection depended on compliance.

What it might look like:

- ◆ People-pleasing or over-apologising
- ◆ Abandoning your own needs to keep others happy
- ◆ Difficulty setting boundaries or saying no
- ◆ Shape-shifting to fit in or avoid rejection

Fawning is about safety through attachment. The body's survival strategy is to make others feel safe, even at your own expense.

Understanding your survival responses allows
you to respond with self-compassion, not self-
criticism



Fight

Arguing, shouting,
bullying, anger, outbursts



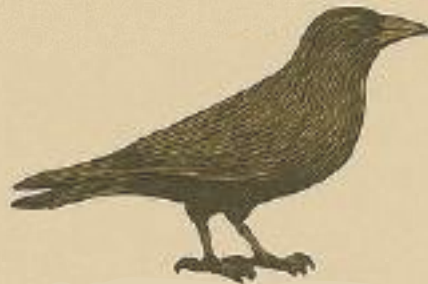
Freeze

Dissociation, feeling
numb, avoidance,
spacing- out



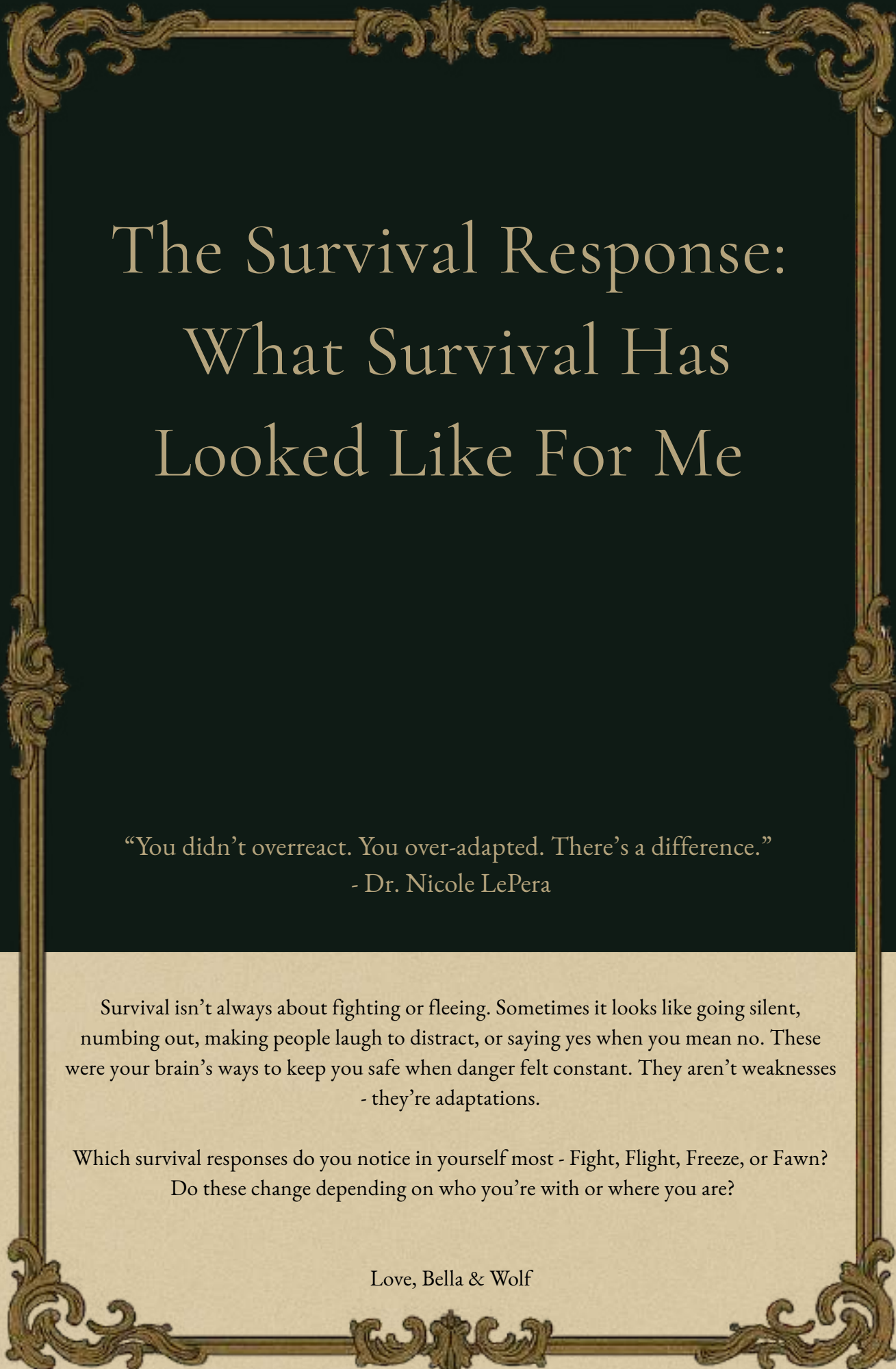
Fawn

people pleasing, lack of
boundaries,
codependency



Flight

perfectionism,
rumination, anxiety,
panic



The Survival Response: What Survival Has Looked Like For Me

“You didn’t overreact. You over-adapted. There’s a difference.”
- Dr. Nicole LePera

Survival isn’t always about fighting or fleeing. Sometimes it looks like going silent, numbing out, making people laugh to distract, or saying yes when you mean no. These were your brain’s ways to keep you safe when danger felt constant. They aren’t weaknesses - they’re adaptations.

Which survival responses do you notice in yourself most - Fight, Flight, Freeze, or Fawn?
Do these change depending on who you’re with or where you are?

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The Window of Tolerance

When you're living with CPTSD, your nervous system isn't just on edge - it's often operating outside its natural capacity to manage stress. That natural capacity is called **the Window of Tolerance**.

Think of it like a zone where your brain and body can function at their best: calm, alert, present, able to think clearly, feel emotions, and respond to stress without becoming overwhelmed. When you're inside the window, life feels manageable - even if it's hard, but trauma shrinks that window.

What Happens Outside the Window?

When something pushes you outside that zone - a trigger, a stressor, a memory, a feeling - your nervous system kicks into survival mode.

There are two main ways we exit the window:

Hyperarousal (Fight, Flight, Fawn)

- ◆ You feel anxious, angry, restless, overwhelmed, panicked, reactive.
- ◆ Your heart races, your thoughts spiral, you might lash out or people-please automatically.

It's your sympathetic nervous system firing on all cylinders.

Hypoarousal (Freeze, Collapse, Shut down)

- ◆ You feel numb, disconnected, exhausted, spaced out, flat, unmotivated.
- ◆ You might dissociate, feel robotic, like you're not really there.

This is your parasympathetic nervous system putting on the brakes too hard.

Why Does It Matter?

When you understand your Window of Tolerance, you stop blaming yourself for being "too emotional", "too cold", "lazy", or "dramatic". You start seeing it for what it is: **a nervous system doing its best to protect you.**

The Window of Tolerance

Expanding Your Window

You can't control your triggers, but you can work on staying inside your window more often. That's what healing is - growing that window over time.

Here's how:

- ◆ Grounding techniques (touch, breath, movement)
- ◆ Therapy
- ◆ Self-soothing strategies (see later chapters)
- ◆ Nervous system regulation tools (cold water, humming, stretching)
- ◆ Restorative relationships (safe people help co-regulate)
- ◆ Healthy routines (sleep, nutrition, structure)

These aren't just nice ideas. They're medicine for a dysregulated system.

If you find yourself constantly outside your window, that doesn't mean you're broken, it means your system is carrying too much. Don't fight your brain for protecting you - thank it, then start giving it what it never got: **safety, stability, and softness.**

Quick Reset: Finding Your Way Back

When you notice you've slipped outside your window, pause before trying to fix or analyse it. First, recognise where you are - am I in fight, flight, freeze, or fawn? The moment you can name it, you've already begun to regulate.

Then come back to your senses - literally. Look around and quietly name:

- ◆ 5 things you can see
- ◆ 4 things you can touch
- ◆ 3 things you can hear
- ◆ 2 things you can smell
- ◆ 1 thing you can taste

You're reminding your brain that you're here, now - not back there, not in danger. Sometimes that's all your body needs to take the first breath of safety.

If that feels too far away, try a small "factory reset": hum, sigh, stretch, or splash cold water on your face.

We will explore deeper self-soothing strategies that actually work later in this book, but for now, think of this as your quick reset when you need to find your footing again.

Your Nervous System Map



Map Your Nervous System States

Use this space to explore how your body, thoughts, and behaviours change depending on which state you're in. Be honest and specific - you're not being judged. You're simply learning your map.

On the following page we have 3 sections:

- ◆ Fight / Flight (Hyperarousal)
- ◆ Window of Tolerance (Regulated)
- ◆ Freeze / Shutdown (Hypoarousal)

1. In each column, answer these prompts:

Body Sensations - what does this state feel like in your body? (e.g. racing heart, numbness, tension, stillness)

Thoughts / Beliefs - what thoughts show up in this state? (e.g. "I'm not safe", "No one cares", "I can't cope")

Behaviours / Reactions - what do you tend to do in this state? (e.g. lash out, shut down, freeze, speak calmly, overthink)

2. Under each column, add some examples of triggers - what kinds of situations push you into this state?

3. Reflect: Where do you spend most of your time? What helps you move back into your Window of Tolerance?

Your Nervous System Map

	Fight/Flight (Hyperarousal)	Window of Tolerance (Regulated)	Freeze/ Shutdown (Hypoarousal)
Bodily sensations			
Thoughts & Beliefs			
Behaviours & Reactions			
Triggers			

Reflections

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines, typical of notebook paper. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no handwriting or other markings on the paper.

Self Soothing Strategies That Actually Work

"Sometimes the most important thing in a whole day is the rest we take
between two deep breaths."

-Etty Hillesum

When you're dysregulated or at crisis point, it is unlikely you're going to recall "5 things you can see, hear, touch..." or attempt to flick through a lengthy book to source soothing strategies so let's be real.

This chapter is about building a toolbox of strategies that actually work and help to strengthen our foundations - not the Instagram perfect ones, but the ones you'll actually use. We're talking body-first approaches, sensory resets, nervous system cues, and practical tools that make sense when your brain is overwhelmed and your emotions are too big to contain.

There's also the emergency stuff in the back of this guide, the quick, no-nonsense tools for when your nervous system is hijacked and you just need something to ground you fast.

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Self-soothing Strategies That Actually Work

What Is Self-Soothing (and Why We Often Get It Wrong)

Self-soothing is the act of calming your nervous system when you're overwhelmed, distressed, or dysregulated. It's what we reach for when our brains and bodies are screaming, "I don't feel safe," even if there's no obvious threat in front of us.

But here's the catch: not all soothing is healthy. Maybe it's scrolling endlessly, numbing with alcohol, addiction, self harm or lashing out at others. These strategies might quiet the panic in the moment- but they don't calm your nervous system, and they often come with long-term costs.

Many of us, especially those who've experienced trauma, didn't learn how to regulate in safe, supportive ways. Instead, we learned what worked in the moment - the things that gave instant relief.

Imagine you're thrown into a relentless battlefield with nothing but a single strand of spaghetti for a weapon. It's thin, fragile, and bends under the weight of the storm. You swing it anyway because it's all you have; it's what keeps you moving, what lets you survive even when it's wet, flopping uselessly, and almost breaking under pressure. That's how early coping works after trauma - improvised, flimsy, but necessary.

You make do with whatever is at hand, even if it doesn't protect you, even if it's painful. Over time, swinging that spaghetti becomes habit: it keeps you alive in the moment, but it doesn't make you stronger.

Now, imagine that over time you are given armour, a proper sword, and a shield that fits. The battle hasn't disappeared, and the enemies haven't vanished - but your tools match the challenge. You can fight with skill instead of desperation, defend without self-injury, and even choose when to advance or retreat.

This is healthy coping: it doesn't remove the storm, but it equips you to face it, to survive with strength, and eventually, to thrive.

Real self-soothing isn't instant, isn't always comfortable, and often feels strange at first. But unlike the flimsy spaghetti, these strategies actually strengthen you. They restore your nervous system, reconnect you to your body, and help you feel genuinely safe - building resilience that lasts long after the storm passes.

Self-soothing Strategies That Actually Work

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- ◆ How to regulate through body, breathe, senses, voice & mind
- ◆ Somatic techniques to ground you in your body
- ◆ How to build a personalised self-soothing menu that actually works

Let's unlearn the old survival patterns and start soothing in a way that heals - not just hides.

Regulation Through Voice

1. Humming

A gentle hum vibrates the vagus nerve, stimulating calm and connection. Try humming a lullaby or any soft tone for 30 seconds.

2. Vagal Toning ("Voo" Sounds)

Make a deep "vooo" sound with your mouth in an open O shape. The low frequency activates your parasympathetic nervous system and brings regulation.

3. Singing Softly

Sing something slow and familiar. It regulates breath, voice, and emotion all at once - and can help restore rhythm if your system feels stuck or flat.

4. Reading Aloud in a Soothing Tone

Pick something gentle - poetry, a favourite paragraph or even a calming script. Reading aloud helps slow the mind, regulate breath, and anchor attention.

Take a moment to notice how your body and voice feel right now. Pick one practice that draws your attention and try it gently. These exercises may feel a bit unusual or even funny at first - and you might laugh while doing them. That's completely okay. Allow whatever you feel or happens to happen. Pay attention to the sensations, the vibrations, and how it shifts your nervous system. Each small act is a piece of armour, a reminder that you can soothe yourself in ways that actually heal.

Self-soothing Strategies That Actually Work

Regulation Through Mind

1.5-4-3-2-1 Grounding Technique

Notice:

- ◆ 5 things you can see
- ◆ 4 things you can touch
- ◆ 3 things you can hear
- ◆ 2 things you can smell
- ◆ 1 thing you can taste

This practice reorients your attention from panic or shutdown back to the present moment.

2. “What’s True Right Now?”

Use this when thoughts spiral.

Ask yourself: What is true in this moment? Anchor in observable facts e.g., “I am safe in this room,” “I have options.”

3. Gentle Journaling:

“What Does This Part of Me Need?”

Instead of trying to silence discomfort, get curious. Write to or from the part of you that feels afraid, angry, or sad. You might discover needs you hadn’t realised were present.

Self-soothing Strategies That Actually Work

Regulation Through the Body

◆ Tapping (Emotional Freedom Therapy / EFT)

Gently tap on acupressure points (like the side of the hand, eyebrow, and under the eye) while naming what you're feeling. This calms the amygdala and helps the nervous system feel safer.

◆ Rocking or Swaying

Slow, rhythmic movement - like gently rocking side to side - can soothe the nervous system by mimicking the motion babies associate with safety and comfort.

◆ Stretching or Yoga (Cat-Cow / Child's Pose)

These gentle movements help release physical tension. Cat-Cow improves spine mobility and connects breath to motion. Child's Pose grounds the body and creates a sense of protection.

◆ Hand on Chest & Slow Breath

Place your hand on your heart, take a slow breath, and feel the warmth and pressure. This activates the parasympathetic nervous system and communicates to your body, "I'm here, I'm safe."

Armour for Your Nervous System

Think of these exercises as the tools you're finally being handed in your battle - the armour, sword, and shield you didn't have before. Which feels like something you could pick up right now? A gentle tap, a slow breath, or a few rocking movements?

Try this mini-practice:

Place a hand on your chest, close your eyes, and take three slow, deliberate breaths. Imagine it as a shield forming around your heart, protecting you from the storm. Feel the weight of your hand like armour, signalling to your nervous system: I am here. I am safe.

Think of it as your battlefield, a reminder that you have tools now, and you don't have to fight with spaghetti anymore.

Self-soothing Strategies That Actually Work

Regulation Through Breath

Your breath is one of the first tools you can carry into the battlefield - the armour that travels with you everywhere. But if traditional patterns feel heavy or triggering, you don't need to force them. The goal is gentle, safe regulation.

◆ Gentle Inhale & Exhale

Breathe naturally, noticing the in-and-out rhythm without holding or forcing. Imagine your breath as a wave rising and falling - soft, steady, flowing. Even small, unhurried breaths signal to your nervous system: I am here. I am safe.

◆ Counting on the Outbreath

Instead of holding or lengthening your inhale, exhale gently while silently counting to 3 or 4. Focus on the release rather than the inhale. This helps your body feel the letting-go, without creating chest pressure that can trigger panic.

◆ Humming or Soft Sighs

Make a low hum or gentle sigh on your exhale. The vibration soothes the vagus nerve, helping your body recognise safety and calm without forcing your lungs or chest.

◆ Breath & Movement Combo

Combine your breath with small movements, like raising your arms slowly as you inhale and lowering as you exhale, or rocking your body. This keeps your nervous system engaged and grounded, letting you feel present without stress.

Armour for Your Breath

Even these gentle, small acts are a form of armour in your battle. Notice how your body responds when you let your breath flow naturally. You don't need to force patterns - just find the rhythm that feels safe. Each inhale and exhale is a tiny sword, shield, or piece of armour, helping you face the storm with tools that actually protect you.

Self-soothing Strategies That Actually Work

Regulation Through Senses

◆ Smell Something Grounding (e.g., lavender, citrus)

Scent goes straight to the limbic system - the part of the brain responsible for emotion and memory. Choose scents that make you feel calm, nostalgic, or safe.

◆ Weighted Blanket

Deep pressure stimulation can lower heart rate and cortisol levels. Use during rest or when trying to down-regulate from stress or shutdown.

◆ Nature Sounds, Brown Noise, or Familiar Low TV

Use consistent, calming background noise to reduce sensory overwhelm and signal safety to the nervous system. Especially useful when you feel scattered or overstimulated.

◆ Mindful Body Scan

Notice each part of your body in turn - from toes to head - without judgement. Pay attention to sensations, tension, or comfort. This quiet awareness grounds your nervous system.

◆ Cold Water Immersion

Splashing cold water on your face, immersing your face in cold water or gently rubbing cubes of ice on wrists/ face/ neck. This activates the body's parasympathetic nervous system, promoting a calming effect and reducing feelings of panic or anxiety.

◆ Tactile Objects

A fidget toy or textured material helps to focus attention on the senses, grounds the body in the present, and distracts from dysregulation.

You don't have to try all of these - notice which ones feel right, explore what works for you. Choose one from the list now to see how it affects your body and mind, notice the sensations and pay attention to how it makes you feel.

Somatic Therapy

What Is Somatic Therapy?

Somatic therapy is a body-based approach to healing that recognises the deep connection between the mind and the nervous system. Trauma, stress, and emotional overwhelm don't just live in our thoughts - they live in our bodies.

When we experience trauma, our nervous system often stays in survival mode long after the danger has passed. You might notice tightness, numbness, restlessness, shallow breathing, or even a sense of shutdown. Somatic therapy helps you notice these signals and respond in ways that shift your state from survival to safety.

Unlike talk therapy, which focuses on exploring thoughts or memories, somatic therapy focuses on what's happening in your body right now.

It's not about "thinking your way out"; it's about feeling your way through, tuning in to the subtle messages your body is sending, and gently guiding your nervous system toward calm.

Many practices in this guide - breathwork, tapping, gentle movement, grounding, humming - come from somatic approaches.

Used consistently, they can help:

- ◆ Calm an overactive nervous system
- ◆ Increase tolerance for stress
- ◆ Release energy that's stuck from trauma
- ◆ Create more moments of safety in your body

Somatic therapy is essentially training your nervous system to recognise safety, rather than forcing it to feel calm. Over time, it helps you feel more connected to yourself, more resilient in stressful moments, and more able to respond rather than react.

Before You Begin the Exercises

Take a moment to notice your body as it is right now. Where do you feel tension, warmth, or pressure? Where do you feel lightness or ease? This simple observation is the first step in connecting with your nervous system and preparing for the exercises ahead.

Somatic Therapy:

DIY

◆ Orienting

Gently turn your head to look around the room. Let your eyes land on whatever feels interesting or comforting. Name what you see: “I see the plant, the lamp, the picture on the wall...” This tells your nervous system: you’re not trapped, you’re safe now.

◆ Tension-Release Sequence

Tense one muscle group at a time - fists, shoulders, legs -then slowly release. Notice the contrast. This mimics the body's natural activation–deactivation cycle and helps stuck energy move.

◆ Butterfly Hug

Cross your arms over your chest so your hands rest on opposite shoulders. Gently tap left–right–left–right. Breathe slowly while doing this. It helps regulate and calm the nervous system, especially during overwhelm.

◆ Self-Holding

Wrap your arms around yourself or place one hand on your heart, the other on your belly. Hold gently. Breathe. Say something comforting internally like, “I’m here. I’ve got you.” It creates a sense of containment and soothing.

◆ Grounding Through Contact

Sit with your feet flat on the floor. Press them gently down. Feel the support of the floor, your chair, and the space around you. You might say aloud: “I feel the ground under me. I’m supported.”

◆ Shake It Out

Stand and shake your arms, legs, hands - whatever wants to move. Let the body release excess energy. You don’t need to “do it right” - just move how your body wants to.

◆ Pendulation

Notice an area in your body that feels tight or activated. Now find an area that feels neutral or safe. Gently go back and forth in your attention - tension, neutral, tension, neutral. This teaches your nervous system that distress doesn’t last forever.

Self-soothing Strategies That Actually Work

When your nervous system is stuck in fight, flight, freeze or fawn, thinking clearly, problem-solving, or connecting with others becomes nearly impossible.

Self-soothing is about creating enough internal safety to re-engage your capacity for choice.
It's the bridge between dysregulation and grounded action.

Nervous System State	Common Symptoms	What Helps	What Doesn't Help
Fight	Angry, agitated, clenched fists/jaw, restless	Movement with control: walking, squeezing a pillow, boxing pacing with breathwork	Sitting still, forced calm, someone saying "just relax"
Flight	Anxious, racing thoughts, fidgety, shallow breathing	Grounding + breath: slow exhales, holding ice, mindfulness	High-stimulation environments, doom-scrolling
Freeze	Numb, shut down, can't move/speak, detached	Gentle activation: warm bath, music, slow rocking, humming, hand on heart	Fast movement, demanding conversation, "snap out of it" approaches
Fawn	People-pleasing, over-apologising, boundary collapse	Self-affirming boundaries: journaling, mantra like "I don't need to fix everything", time alone	Social media, over-explaining, immediate people contact

Build Your Own Soothing Menu

Your Personal Self-Soothing Menu

- ◆ Create a list of go-to strategies based on how your nervous system responds in different states.
- ◆ Start by identifying your signs (e.g. clenched jaw, frozen posture, racing heart),
- ◆ Match them with techniques that feel realistic and supportive.

Here's a layout to guide you:

When I'm in Fight Mode, I Can Try...

Body Signs I Might Notice:

(e.g., clenched jaw, rapid speech, feeling irritable or defensive)

When I'm in Flight Mode, I Can Try...

(Examples: child's pose, weighted blanket, box breathing)

Body Signs I Might Notice:

(e.g., racing heart, restlessness, pacing)

Build Your Own Soothing Menu

When I'm in Freeze Mode, I Can Try...

(Examples: hand on chest + breath, tapping, soft music)

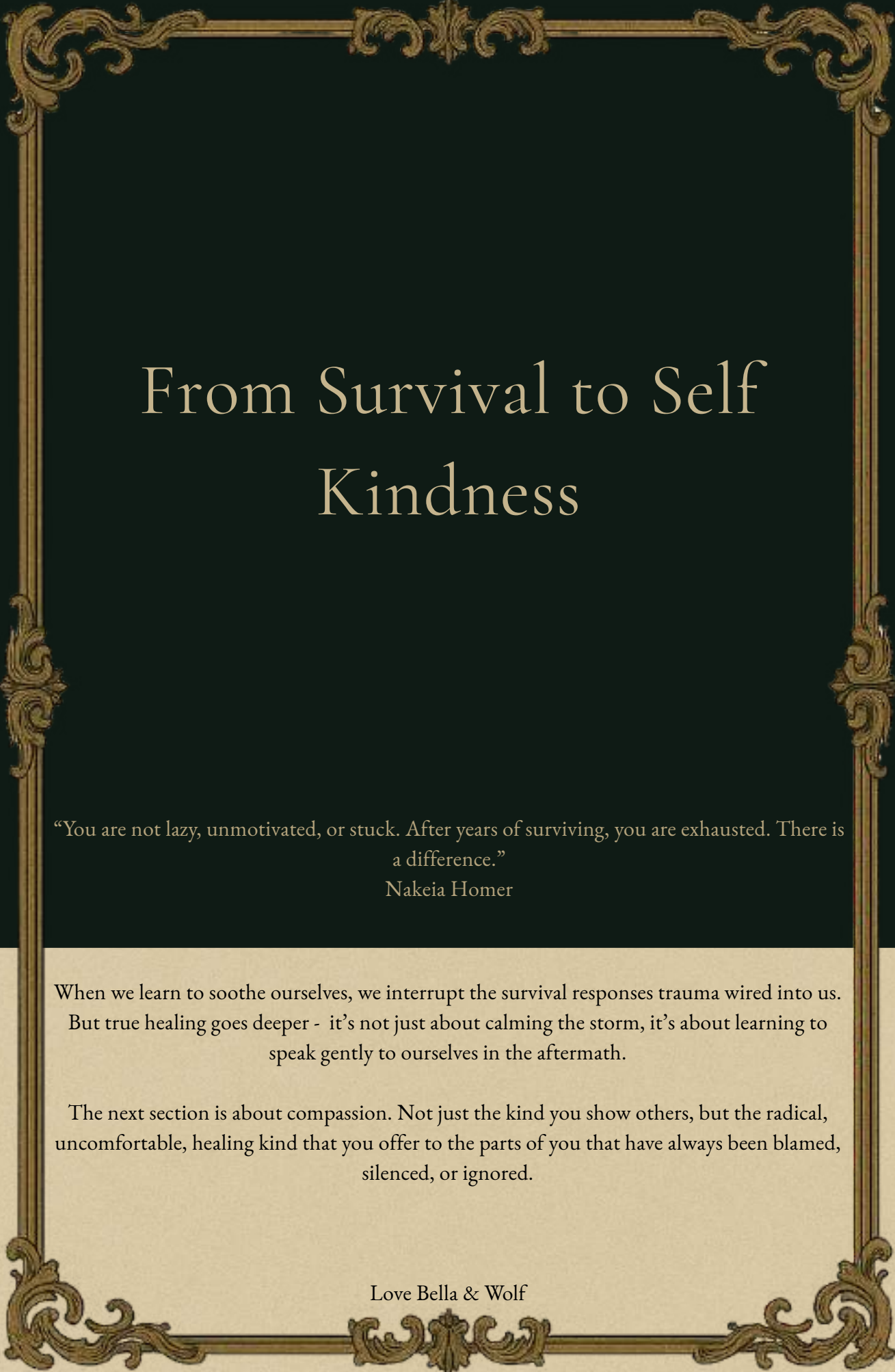
Body Signs I Might Notice:

(e.g., numbness, zoning out, heavy limbs)

(Examples: journaling "what do I need?", reading aloud, stretching)

Body Signs I Might Notice:

(e.g., over-apologising, people-pleasing, loss of own opinions)



From Survival to Self Kindness

“You are not lazy, unmotivated, or stuck. After years of surviving, you are exhausted. There is a difference.”

Nakeia Homer

When we learn to soothe ourselves, we interrupt the survival responses trauma wired into us. But true healing goes deeper - it's not just about calming the storm, it's about learning to speak gently to ourselves in the aftermath.

The next section is about compassion. Not just the kind you show others, but the radical, uncomfortable, healing kind that you offer to the parts of you that have always been blamed, silenced, or ignored.

Love Bella & Wolf

What is Compassion?

We throw the word around a lot - but what does it actually mean?

Compassion isn't just a soft emotion or a fluffy concept.

It's not passive.

It's not indulgent. True compassion is a response.

It sees pain - yours or someone else's - and chooses to meet it with care, not criticism.

At its core, compassion is the practice of noticing suffering (internal or external), recognising that it's part of the shared human experience, and responding with kindness, not judgement. That response might be gentle or firm, stillness or action - but it always comes from a place of dignity and care.

For most of my life, I understood compassion as a concept, not an experience. I could see others being hard on themselves and step in immediately - I heard someone call themselves "stupid" or say something cruel about their body or worth. I had this reflex where I'd ask,

"Would you speak to your 10-year-old self that way?"

That question always created a pause. A disruption.

It interrupted the automatic, brutal self-talk and offered a moment of reflection - often the first time someone realised how normalised their inner critic had become.

But while I could extend that compassion so naturally to others, I struggled to turn it inward. I could intellectualise self-compassion, explain why it mattered, even teach it - but I wasn't embodying it.

I wasn't living it.

Over time, I began to learn that compassion isn't just about feelings - it lives in routine.

It's in the behaviour.

It's choosing to stop working an hour earlier even when I feel guilty.

It's deciding not to skip lunch because my body matters.

It's the boring, ordinary decisions I make to protect my well being without needing to "earn" it.

That's compassion. It's not a feeling you wait for. It's a practice you commit to.

Understanding compassion is one thing, feeling it in your bones is another. Sometimes, the parts of us that have been silenced, shamed, or hurt need more than words - they need a story, a space, a ritual to meet them where they are. The next exercise invites you to utilise the wood, fire, and water: a place where you can access the basics to survive and offer care to the parts of yourself that need it most.

The Wood, the Fire, and the Water: A Compassion Practice

Ahead, three elements await your attention: Wood & Kindling: Solid, sturdy, ready to create warmth and shelter. Fire: Flickering, alive, full of energy and transformation. Water: Cool, flowing, gentle, and nourishing. Pause and notice which element draws you first. Trust your instinct.

◆ Step 1: Explore Your Tools

You already have what you need to survive - and even to thrive. The forest provides the resources; you simply need to learn how to use them.

Wood & Kindling: Imagine gathering the pieces. Each one represents your strengths, resilience, or skills. Arrange them carefully, preparing them to hold a steady flame.

Fire: Light it gently. Feel its warmth, not as something threatening, but as a source of courage, energy, and transformation. Notice how it can purify while illuminating your path.

Water: Pour it over your hands, into a pot, or let it flow into the earth. Water nurtures, refreshes, and restores. Notice how your body responds to its presence.

◆ Step 2: Invite Your Wounded or Younger Self

Bring to mind a part of you that has carried trauma, fear, or pain. Imagine them standing beside you, hesitant but curious.

Show them how to use the elements: Build warmth with wood and fire, demonstrating that strength and courage can be created and tended.

Offer water, showing how to nurture, soothe, and replenish energy.

Notice how this part of you softens, breathes easier, and relaxes, recognising that care can be deliberate and gentle, not just survival.

◆ Step 3: Allow What Happens to Happen

These exercises may feel unusual or even funny. You might laugh, fidget, or notice unexpected sensations - and that's okay. Allow whatever arises. Observe your body, your emotions, and your breath without judgement.

◆ Step 4: Reflect and Carry It With You

Step back and observe the fire you've built, the warmth and light you've created, the water you've poured. These are your skills, resilience, and compassion - resources you already carry.

Take a deep, grounding breath and say quietly to yourself:

"I have what I need. I can use it to care for myself. I can nourish, protect, and heal."

Your Elements in Action

◆ Which element drew your attention most? Wood, Fire, or Water?

◆ What did you notice in your body - warmth, tension, ease, tingling?

◆ What emotions or thoughts came up? Fear, relief, curiosity, joy?

◆ Did anything surprise you - laughing, shifting, discomfort or feeling heavier/ lighter?

◆ What do you think the purpose of this exercise was?

◆ What did you feel you got out of it?

◆ How could you use this element in your daily life to support, soothe, or energise yourself?

Compassion as Resistance: Rewriting the rule book

“Self-compassion is not letting yourself off the hook. It’s refusing to hang yourself with it.”

What You’ll Need:

A pen and paper (or your journal) & a quiet space to reflect or a group to share with.

◆ Step 1: Spot the Internalised Belief

Reflect on one or more of the following prompts. Write your answers without censoring yourself.

I was taught that I’m only
worthy when...

I feel ashamed when I...

I believe I have to _____
before I’m allowed to rest.

◆ Step 2: Locate the Source

Ask: Where did this come
from?

Was it childhood? School? A
trauma response? White
supremacy culture? Naming
the source separates it from
your identity.

◆ Step 3: Rewrite It Now flip

the script. Write a compassionate
alternative in your voice.

Examples:

Old Rule: “I’m lazy if I rest.”

Compassionate Rewrite: “Rest is
resistance. I don’t have to earn
it.”

old rule: “I need to be useful to
be loved.”

Compassionate Rewrite: “I am
worthy even when I am still.”

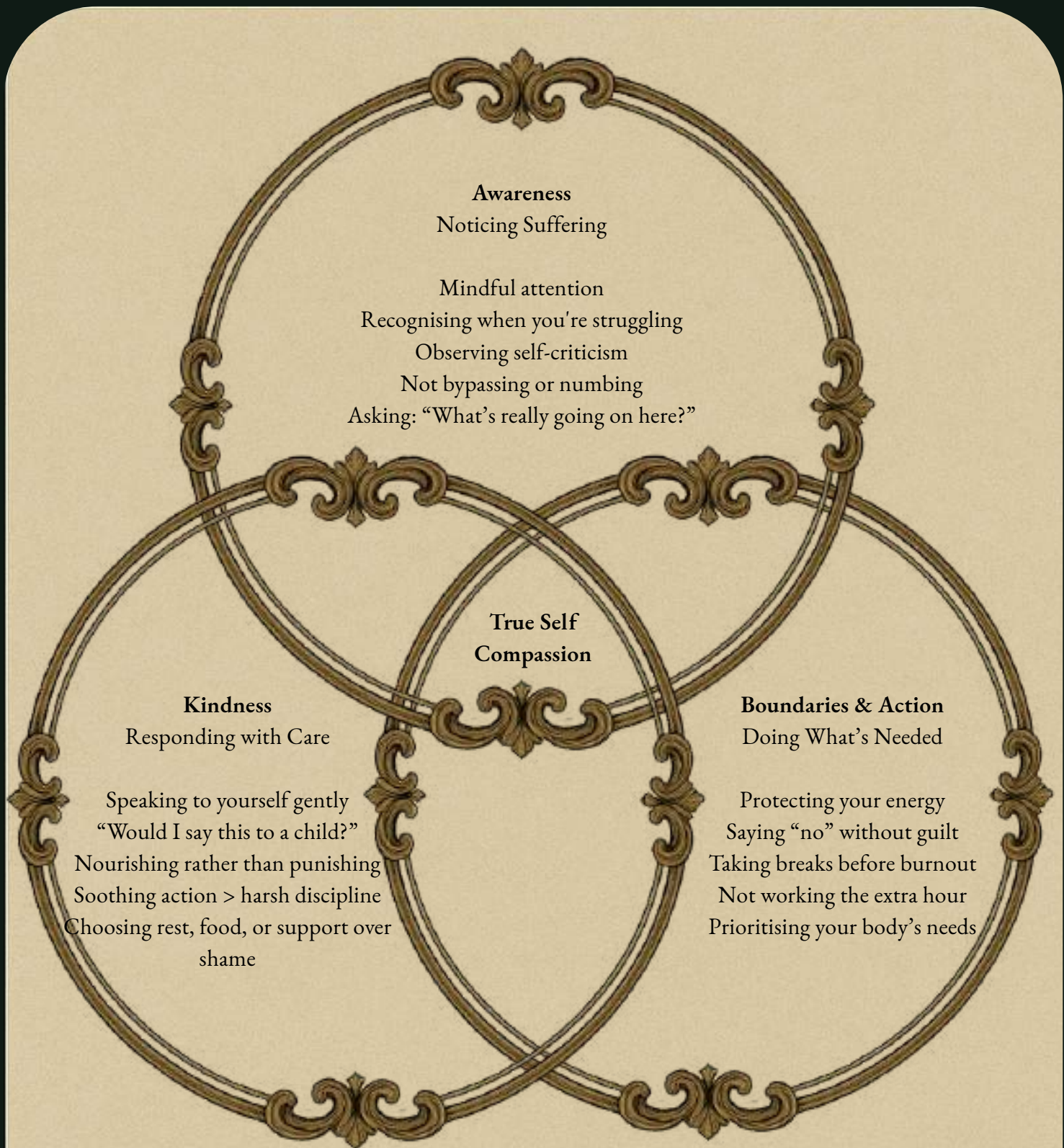
◆ Step 4: Make It Tangible

Turn your most powerful
rewrite into a:

- ◆ Affirmation card
- ◆ Phone wallpaper
- ◆ Sticky note on your mirror

Decorate it. Make it sacred.

The Anatomy of Compassion: Awareness, Kindness & Action



Compassion isn't just a feeling - it's a decision, a discipline, and a way of relating to yourself with dignity.

The Anatomy of Compassion: Do It Yourself

Putting Compassion Into Practice

You've already learned how to regulate through your body, breath, senses, and voice - how to ground yourself when your system starts to spin, how to soothe instead of suppress, how to return to safety when your body feels like it's turned against you.

Those tools taught you how to find calm.

This next section asks you to go deeper, to learn how to meet yourself once you've found it.

Compassion is the bridge between survival and healing.

It's what turns regulation into restoration. You can calm your body, but if your inner voice still attacks you when you rest - if guilt or shame still speak louder than care - your system never fully believes it's safe. Compassion changes that. You've just seen how compassion is made up of awareness, kindness, and boundaries- each essential, but most powerful when they come together.

Together, they form the anatomy of true self-compassion: noticing your suffering, responding gently, and taking actions that protect and nurture you.

You'll have space to explore how awareness, kindness, and boundaries play out in your life, moments when you've shown up for yourself and moments you haven't. Notice what helps you soften, what makes you close off, what you need more of. These reflections help you understand not just how you survive, but how you begin to feel safe enough to live. There are no right or wrong answers here. Compassion isn't a destination; it's a relationship you keep building.

What You'll Need

- ◆ A pen and your journal (or these pages)
- ◆ A calm space where you can pause and reflect
- ◆ Optional: something grounding - a blanket, fidget or soothing scent

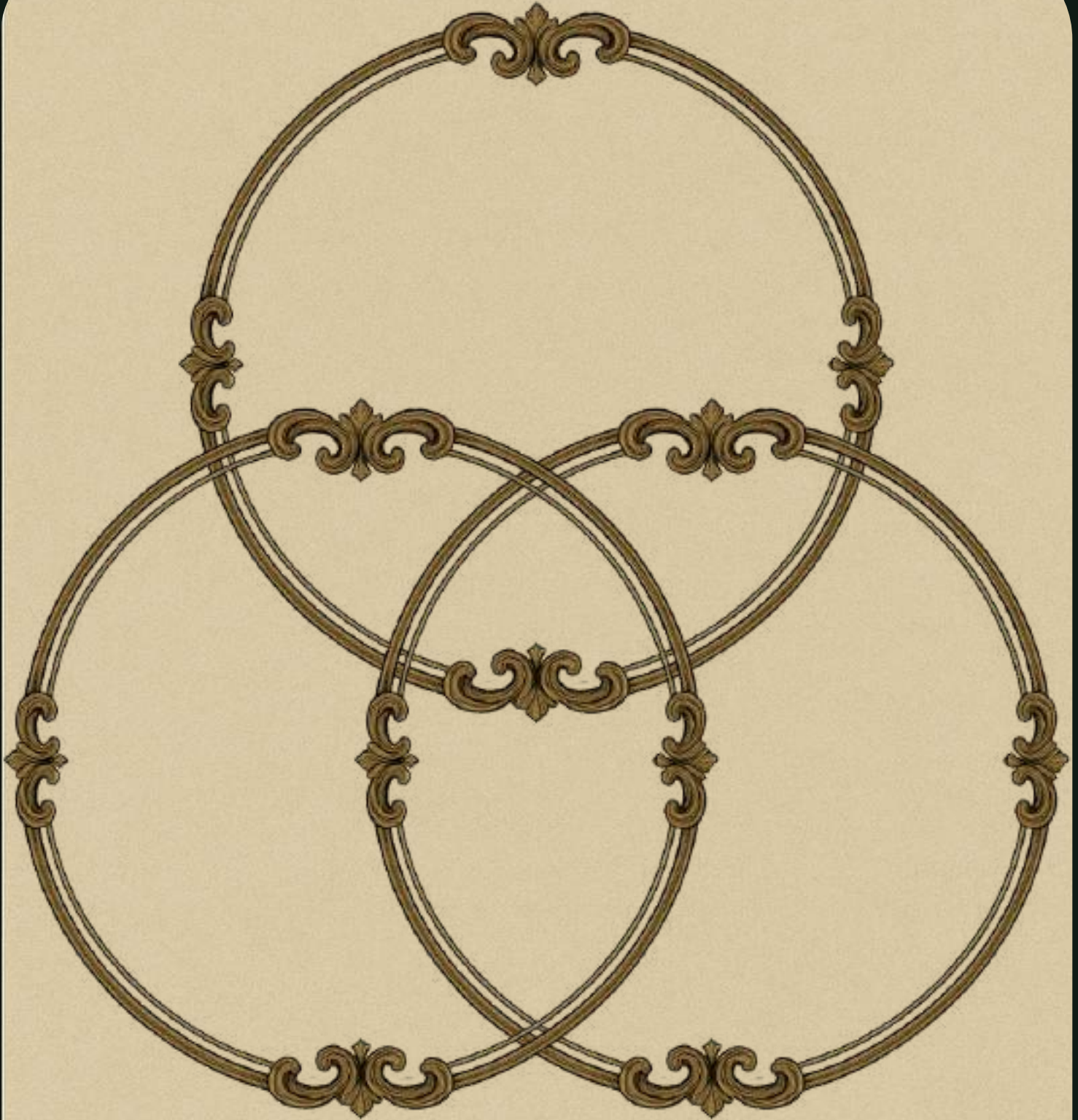
How to Use This Section

In the next few pages, you'll have space to explore how awareness, kindness, and boundaries show up in your life.

You'll complete the Anatomy of Compassion Venn diagram, then move into a series of reflection and journaling prompts designed to help you recognise your patterns - where compassion flows freely, and where it gets blocked.

The Anatomy of Compassion: Do It Yourself

“Compassion isn’t a reward for being perfect. It’s how I survive being human.”



The Anatomy of Compassion:

Do It Yourself

A practical exercise to connect with yourself, notice suffering, and respond with self-compassion in action. Take your time with each step. There are no “right” answers, it’s about curiosity and care.

Kindness - Responding with Care

◆ Pause and ask yourself: “If I treated myself like someone I love, what would I say or do right now?”

◆ Notice when you’re suffering - physically, mentally, or emotionally. Ask: “What would kindness look like here, in action?”

◆ Identify one small comforting act you can give yourself today. Examples: holding a warm cup of tea, placing a hand on your chest, or allowing yourself a short rest.

◆ Optional journaling prompt: Write down the kind words or actions you’d offer.

Awareness - Noticing Suffering

◆ The purpose is to recognise your signals before they escalate and acknowledge your experience without judgement. Check in with your body and mind: “What signs tell me I’m struggling emotionally or physically?”

The Anatomy of Compassion: Do It Yourself

◆ Reflect on patterns: “What do I usually ignore, minimise, or push through?”

Take a moment to pause and name your feelings. Examples: “I feel tense and anxious” or “I’m exhausted and sad.”

◆ Optional journaling prompt: Note how your body feels, what thoughts are present, and what emotions are underlying.

Boundaries & Action - Doing What’s Needed

◆ The purpose is to protect your well-being and act in alignment with your needs. Identify what you need to protect or prioritise that often gets overlooked. Examples: sleep, food, safe space, mental rest.

◆ Reflect on recent patterns: “Where have I been overriding my body or emotions?”

◆ Decide on one boundary or action you can set today in the name of self-respect. Examples: saying no to a task, stepping away from social media, or taking a short walk.

The Anatomy of Compassion:

Do It Yourself

◆ Decide on one boundary or action you can set today in the name of self-respect. Examples: saying no to a task, stepping away from social media, or taking a short walk.

◆ Optional journaling prompt: Write down your chosen boundary or action and visualise yourself honouring it.

True Self Compassion - Compassion in Practice

◆ The purpose is to integrate noticing, responding, and acting into a holistic self-compassion practice. “What does it look like when I notice my suffering, respond kindly, and take action all at once?”

◆ Think of a recent challenge. Imagine how applying all three steps - kindness, awareness, and action - could have changed how you responded.

◆ Optional journaling prompt: Describe a new, compassionate approach you can try if a similar challenge arises.

Compassion as Resistance

“To rest is radical. To treat myself kindly is an act of resistance against every system that told me I had to suffer to be worthy.”

We’ve explored how compassion shows up through awareness, kindness, and boundaries and how these practices help us return to safety through the body, breath, and senses. Now, we begin to see that compassion isn’t just a personal act of care; it’s a quiet form of rebellion. Every time we choose gentleness over judgement, or rest over relentless striving, we resist the systems that taught us to survive by abandoning ourselves.

Compassion isn’t just soft or sentimental - it’s radical.

It’s a refusal to keep internalising systems of punishment, perfectionism, and productivity that treat human needs as weaknesses.

When we practise compassion, especially in a world that encourages burnout, self-criticism, and emotional numbing, we are actively resisting those messages. It is political, spiritual, and deeply personal.

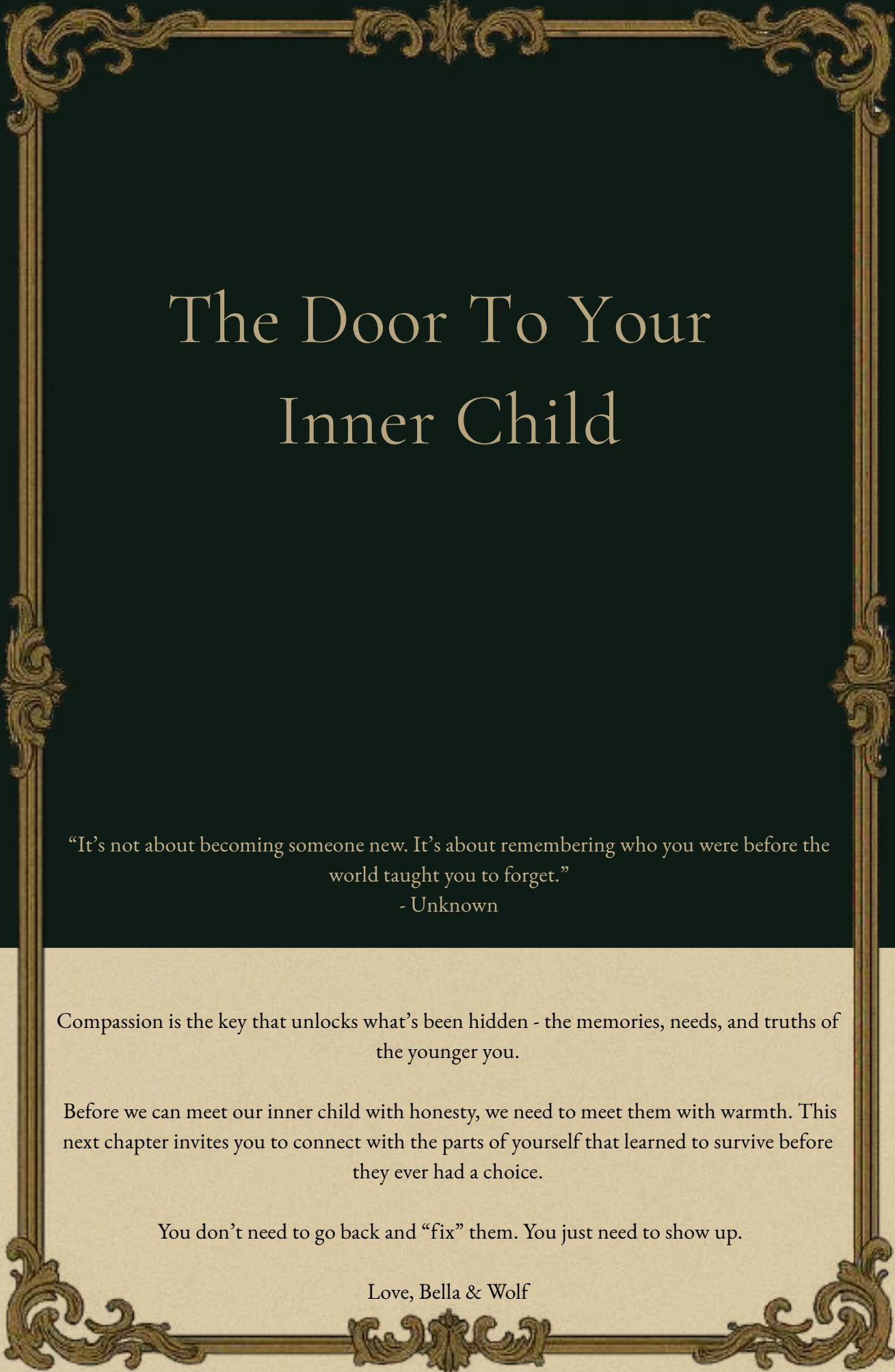
Think about it:

- ◆ Capitalism tells us our worth is based on what we produce.
- ◆ Compassion says you are worthy even when you rest.
- ◆ Trauma conditions us to ignore our pain or push through it.
- ◆ Compassion says you deserve to be cared for, especially in pain.
- ◆ Internalised shame whispers that we’re “too much,” “not enough,” or “broken.”
- ◆ Compassion interrupts that and says your needs are valid.

For me, compassion became a form of rebellion. Every time I stopped myself from working that extra hour, skipped a task instead of a meal, or chose to speak gently to myself - it was an act of resistance. Every time I helped someone else stop the spiral of self-blame, I was disrupting a legacy of shame.

This is the kind of resistance that rewires.

Not overnight. But steadily. Repetition over intensity. It’s not about perfect kindness - it’s about choosing tenderness again and again, even when it feels unnatural.



The Door To Your Inner Child

“It’s not about becoming someone new. It’s about remembering who you were before the world taught you to forget.”

- Unknown

Compassion is the key that unlocks what’s been hidden - the memories, needs, and truths of the younger you.

Before we can meet our inner child with honesty, we need to meet them with warmth. This next chapter invites you to connect with the parts of yourself that learned to survive before they ever had a choice.

You don’t need to go back and “fix” them. You just need to show up.

Love, Bella & Wolf

My Inner Child & Me

"I didn't even realise I was abandoning myself again and again - not out of malice, but out of habit. My inner child wasn't loud or dramatic. She was quiet, observant, waiting for someone to notice. I had to become the one who noticed."

We all carry within us a younger version of ourselves - a tender, formative part that still lives inside us, shaped by early experiences, unmet needs, and moments of joy or fear. This is our inner child. They're not a metaphor. They're real, emotional echoes of who we once were and how we learned to survive. They show up in the present: in how we respond to conflict, how we seek comfort, how we feel when we're overwhelmed, and how we interpret abandonment, love, and safety.

Why This Work Matters

Connecting with your inner child isn't just emotional fluff - it's a radical act of reconnection. It's about giving language to pain that was once silent, soothing wounds that went unattended, and creating the safety we never had. It's also about celebrating the magic, curiosity, and imagination that may have been buried under the weight of survival.

For years, I could offer kindness to everyone but myself. I'd instinctively soothe others, interrupt their negativity until a crack formed in the autopilot cruelty directed inward. And yet, I still struggled to extend the same grace to myself. I could understand the principle, but I couldn't feel it. I intellectualised it, kept it at arm's length.

What helped? Defiant acts of care for the part of me that still panics when things feel unsafe.

Start Here: Meet Them

Take a few moments and think back to yourself at age 5, or 7, or 10. Choose an age that feels emotionally relevant. Then ask:

What were they afraid of?
What did they need?
Who did they want to be?
What made them laugh?
What broke their heart?

You may want to find a photo from that time. Look at it gently. Speak to them out loud or write a letter. This isn't about digging up trauma - it's about seeing them, hearing them, and building a bridge. There's space on the following pages for exactly this.

A Letter From My Younger Self

Write a letter from your inner child to you today. Let them speak freely. What do they need you to hear?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

A Letter To My Younger Self

Write a letter to your younger self - the one who lived through what you did. Speak with kindness, understanding, and honesty. What would you want them to know? What comfort, reassurance, or wisdom could you offer?

This is a chance to hold space for your past and offer the support you may not have received then.
Let your words be gentle, real, and healing.

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From Wounds to Words

“Don’t believe everything you think.”
-Byron Katie

When we reconnect with our inner child, we often uncover the root of the stories we carry - stories about being too much, not enough, unlovable, unsafe.

The next chapter helps you challenge those inherited beliefs, and bridging your inner child work and understanding how untrue thoughts are a symptom of trauma. These thoughts aren’t facts - they’re echoes of pain, shaped by survival. Let’s hold them up to the light.

Love, Bella & Wolf

The Stuff Your Brain Tells You That Isn't True

Your brain is a liar.

That might sound harsh, but it's true. Especially when you're living with trauma, the mind becomes a storyteller - but not the kind you want at the wheel. It spins narratives that sound convincing but are rooted in fear, shame, and outdated survival strategies.

It tells you you're a burden.

That people are better off without you.

That one mistake defines you.

That everything is going to fall apart.

That no one else thinks this way.

That you're not good enough.

That you're too much.

Let's be clear: just because a thought is loud, doesn't make it true. Just because it feels real, doesn't mean it is real.

◆ Shame-Based Thoughts

"It was my fault." "I'm broken." "I ruin everything." "I'm not enough"

Shame is one of trauma's most powerful weapons. It tells you that your worth is defined by what happened to you. That you're damaged or defective. But shame isn't a fact- it's an emotional residue left by experiences where you were hurt, blamed, or made to feel invisible.

It's not that you are bad. It's that bad things happened to you, and your brain tried to make sense of it by turning it inward.

◆ Guilt Loops

"I should've done more." "If I had just said something, maybe..."

This is the voice of hindsight. Trauma survivors often replay moments obsessively, believing they could've stopped what happened. But in trauma, your body responds automatically - fight, flight, freeze, or fawn.

You don't choose those responses. You survive them.

Guilt may feel like control, but it's often misplaced responsibility.

You weren't in control. You just lived through it.

The Stuff Your Brain Tells You That Isn't True

◆ Worst-Case Scenario Thinking

“Something bad is going to happen.” “I can’t trust anyone.” “They’ve not replied, they must be hate me”

When trauma rewires your nervous system, it turns up the threat detection system. Your brain expects danger- always. You might constantly scan for signs something’s wrong, catastrophise small setbacks, or assume rejection is coming.

This isn’t paranoia, it’s protection.

But it’s not based in the present.

It’s your body stuck in a past that’s over.

◆ Black-and-White Thinking

“I have to get it perfect, or I’ve failed.” “They either love me or they hate me.”

Trauma doesn’t do nuance.

Your brain splits everything into extremes: safe vs unsafe, good vs evil, success vs disaster.

That kept you alive in chaos. But in everyday life, it creates emotional whiplash and rigid expectations that no one - including you - can meet.

It makes healing hard, because healing lives in the grey areas.

◆ Fear-Based Avoidance

“I can’t cope with that.” “It’s safer if I just stay home.” “If I ignore it, it will go away”

Avoidance feels protective. It calms your nervous system in the short term. But long-term, it shrinks your world and it teaches your brain that discomfort equals danger. The more you avoid, the less confidence you have in your ability to cope.

You’re not fragile. Your brain just hasn’t had enough safe experiences yet to believe you’re capable.

◆ Intrusive Thoughts

“What if I hurt someone?” “I’m a bad person for thinking this.”

Intrusive thoughts are unwanted, distressing mental images or ideas.

They’re often violent, sexual, or shame-inducing.

They feel dangerous, but they’re not.

Intrusive thoughts are a symptom of anxiety and hyperarousal, not evidence of intent or character.

They’re mental noise from a nervous system stuck in overdrive, and the important thing to remember is that they’re egodystonic - meaning they go against your values, your identity, and who you truly are.

The very fact that they distress you proves they don’t define you.

The Stuff Your Brain Tells You That Isn't True

“The more you try to suppress them, the more powerful they seem. But they lose power when you stop treating them like facts.”

Before you dive into the next activity, pause for a moment.

Which of these thought patterns feels the loudest or most familiar in your life right now?

Taking a moment to notice what's most active helps ground you and makes the next step feel less like homework and more like self-discovery.

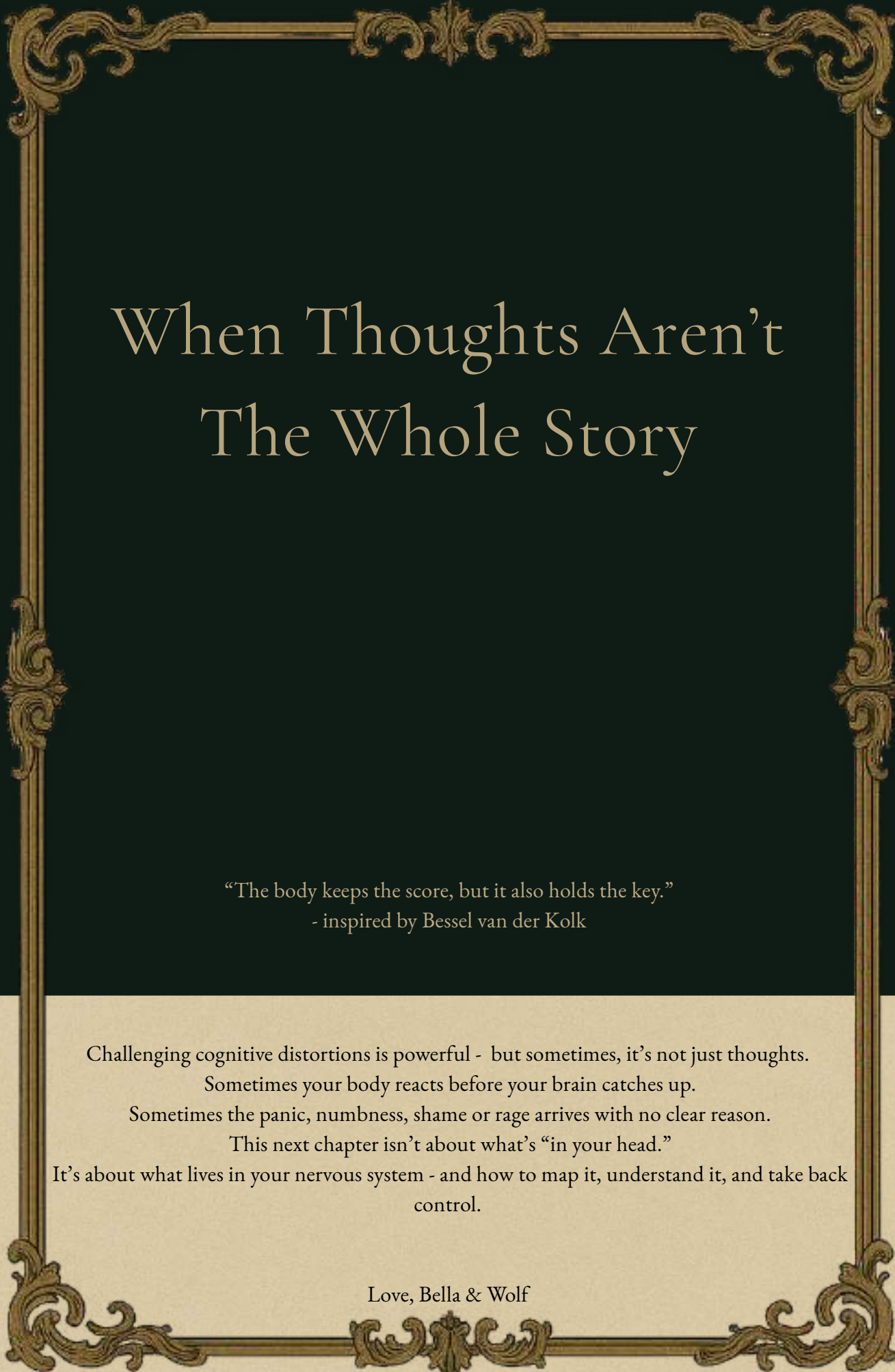
Reflections

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Challenge Your Thoughts: Finding the Balance

Write down common negative thoughts. What's the wound beneath them? Now re-frame them with a more balanced, compassionate voice.

"I always ruin things."	Shame, fear of rejection. Based on one past incident that left a wound.	"I've struggled, yes. But I've also learned and grown. One mistake doesn't define me."
"They didn't reply - they hate me."	Abandonment fear, hypervigilance.	"There could be 100 reasons, they may be busy with work or gotten distracted. I can tolerate not knowing right now."



When Thoughts Aren't The Whole Story

“The body keeps the score, but it also holds the key.”
- inspired by Bessel van der Kolk

Challenging cognitive distortions is powerful - but sometimes, it's not just thoughts.
Sometimes your body reacts before your brain catches up.
Sometimes the panic, numbness, shame or rage arrives with no clear reason.
This next chapter isn't about what's “in your head.”
It's about what lives in your nervous system - and how to map it, understand it, and take back control.

Love, Bella & Wolf

Understanding Triggers & Flashbacks

What Are Triggers?

Triggers are stimuli - internal or external - that remind your nervous system of past trauma. They can be obvious, like a loud noise, a certain date, a smell, or a specific location. Or they can be subtle, like a tone of voice, a facial expression, or even a bodily sensation.

The amygdala, which helps us detect danger and store emotional memories, flags perceived threats based on past experiences. Sometimes it's wrong, but it doesn't know that. It's using old maps to navigate current roads. Types of triggers:

- ◆ External: sights, sounds, smells, locations, people, social dynamics, or seasonal reminders.
- ◆ Internal: emotions (feeling helpless, anxious, or sad), bodily sensations (racing heart, tension), thoughts ("I'm not safe"), or even dreams.

What Are Flashbacks?

Flashbacks are intense re-experiencing of past trauma. They can show up in several ways:

- ◆ Visual: like watching a movie of the event in your mind.
- ◆ Emotional: sudden floods of fear, shame, rage, or grief.
- ◆ Somatic: physical sensations without an obvious cause.
- ◆ Dissociative: feeling disconnected from the present, as if you're somewhere else.

Not all flashbacks are dramatic or cinematic. Many people with CPTSD experience emotional flashbacks which are sudden waves of shame, panic, or dread that feel far bigger than what's happening in the moment.

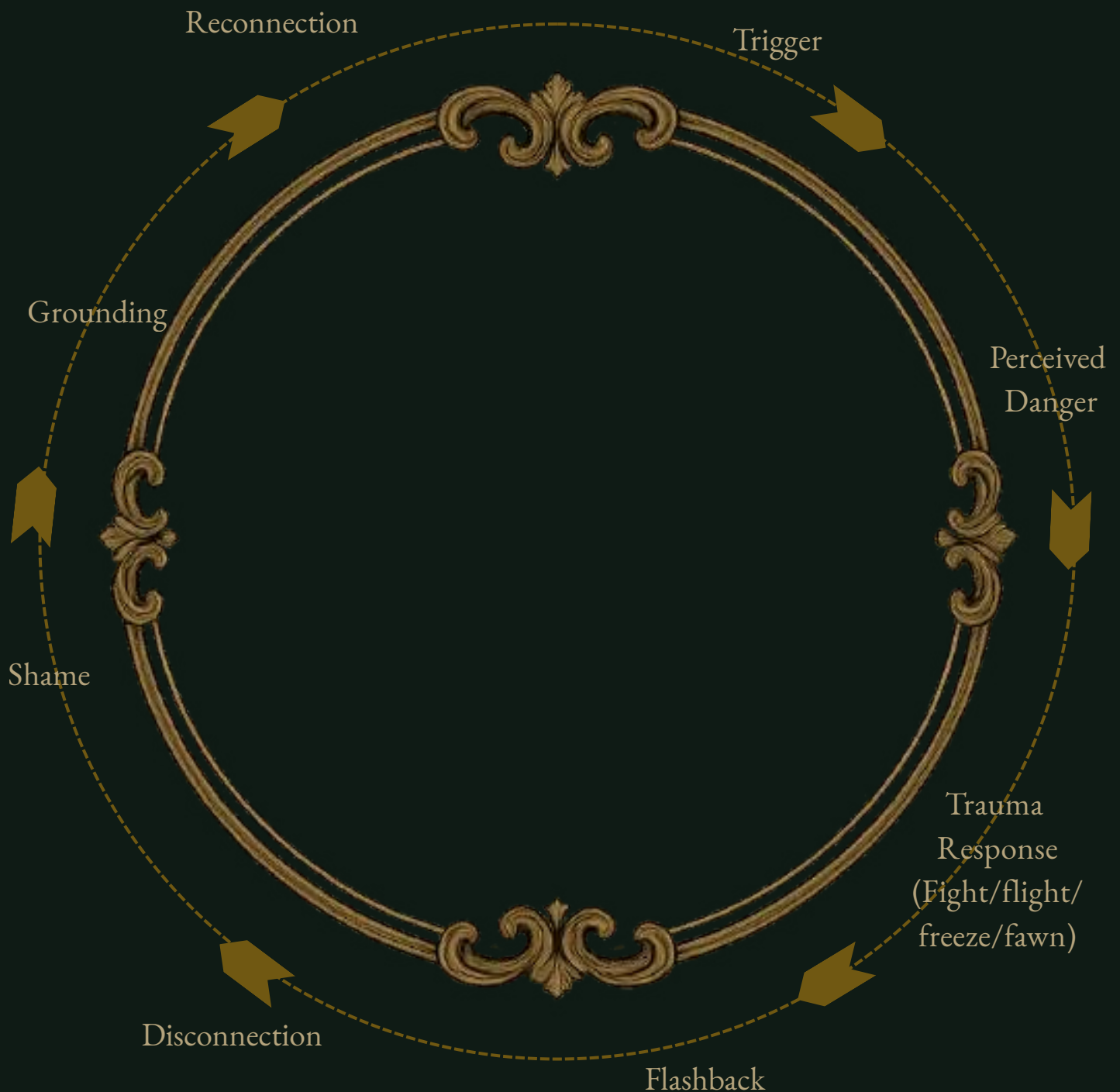
How Triggers and Flashbacks Affect Us

- ◆ Hijack our ability to think clearly
- ◆ Make us respond to the present as if we're back in the past
- ◆ Create shame or self-blame for "overreacting"
- ◆ Lead to coping behaviours - numbing, avoidance, anger - that are protective in the moment, but may not help in the long-term

The Central Cycle

Triggers activate an automatic response that can plunge us into a flashback - reliving past trauma in the present. This cycle hijacks both mind and body, blurring the line between "then" and "now." Recognising this pattern is crucial: it gives us the power to pause, intervene, and slowly break the cycle, moving toward safety and healing. The next pages show how triggers and flashbacks link to negative symptoms, helping us recognise patterns and start regaining safety.

Trigger to Flashback: The Central Cycle



The Central Cycle shows how a trigger can set off a chain reaction in the nervous system. A perceived danger activates a trauma response - fight, flight, freeze, or fawn - which can lead into a flashback, disconnection, and shame. Grounding and reconnection are the steps that help break the cycle, bringing us back to the present and a sense of safety.

Understanding Triggers & Flashbacks

This page helps us break the cycle down step by step. By noticing what triggers us, how our body and mind respond, what a flashback feels like, and the ways we can repair, we start to see the patterns clearly. Understanding each stage gives us the power to intervene, use our coping tools, and return to the present safely.



Trigger Tracker & Flashback Decoder

◆ What happened just before I felt off?
(e.g. I got a text and felt a knot in my stomach)

◆ What did I feel in my body?
(e.g. heart racing, cold hands, tension in jaw)

◆ What did my brain start telling me?
(e.g. "They're going to leave me" or "I've messed everything up")

Trigger Tracker & Flashback Decoder

◆ What did I do next?

(e.g. shut down, argued, self-soothed, scrolled, drank)

◆ What happened just before I felt off?

(e.g. I got a text and felt a knot in my stomach)

◆ What might this be linked to from my past?

(e.g. arguments with dad, feeling abandoned, not being believed)

◆ What does my nervous system need now?

(e.g. grounding, a hug, silence, deep breaths)

From Cycles to Life: Understanding How Trauma Impacts Daily Living

Understanding How Trauma Impacts Daily Living

Trauma isn't just about isolated moments of flashbacks or shame - it's more like dropping a stone into a pond. The ripples spread out, touching every part of your life: how you manage emotions, how you see yourself, your daily routines, and even what brings you joy.

These ripples aren't always obvious. Sometimes they show up as feeling overwhelmed by small things, struggling to trust yourself or others, or losing interest in activities you once loved. Other times, they show in the way your body reacts or how you relate to people.

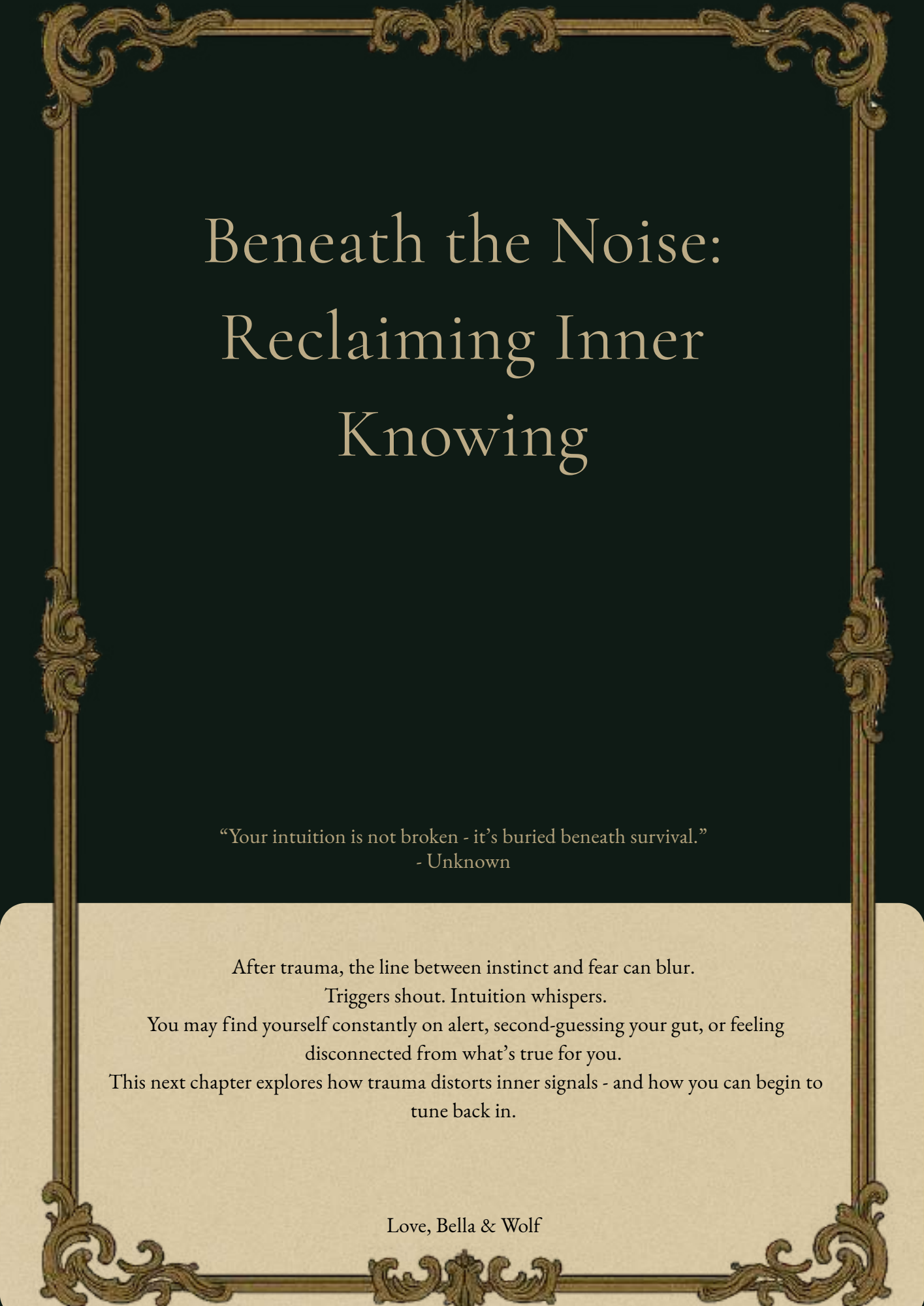
The next page shows a detailed map of these ripples. It might look complex, but think of it as a way to see how each wave connects and influences the others. Understanding this bigger picture can help you spot patterns and know where to focus your energy.

You've already met the central cycle. It might be helpful to refer back to that diagram as you explore how this core circle sends waves into the rest of your world.

This isn't about overwhelm- it's about gaining clarity and taking small, steady steps toward reclaiming your identity and building a life that feels more yours.

The Trigger-to-Flashback Cycle & Real-Life Impact Map





Beneath the Noise: Reclaiming Inner Knowing

“Your intuition is not broken - it’s buried beneath survival.”
- Unknown

After trauma, the line between instinct and fear can blur.
Triggers shout. Intuition whispers.
You may find yourself constantly on alert, second-guessing your gut, or feeling
disconnected from what’s true for you.
This next chapter explores how trauma distorts inner signals - and how you can begin to
tune back in.

Love, Bella & Wolf

Intuition & CPSTD - A Checklist

Rebuilding trust in your gut after trauma

CPTSD scrambles your internal compass. When you've been gaslit, ignored, or punished for speaking up, your intuition can feel like a liability instead of a guide. You start second-guessing everything - not because you're indecisive, but because your nervous system learned that safety meant compliance, not clarity.

Signs CPTSD has impacted your connection to intuition:

- ◆ I often override my gut feeling to avoid conflict or keep the peace.
- ◆ I feel unsafe making decisions without external validation.
- ◆ I distrust my own perception, even when evidence supports it.
- ◆ I've felt punished or shamed for speaking up in the past.
- ◆ I struggle to identify what I actually want, need, or feel.
- ◆ I question whether my boundaries are "too much" or "not valid."
- ◆ I confuse trauma responses (like fawning or freezing) with intuition.
- ◆ I default to analysing others' needs before recognising my own.
- ◆ I feel anxious or guilty when I say "no" - even when it's reasonable.
- ◆ I find myself thinking "Is it me?" more than "Is this safe?"

Intuition & CPSTD - A Checklist

Rebuilding trust in your gut after trauma

This checklist isn't a diagnosis. It's a mirror. It's here to help you notice where the fracture lines are, and where repair is possible.

Signs you're starting to reconnect with your intuition:

- ◆ I pause before responding instead of reacting from panic or pattern.
- ◆ I can notice when something feels "off" without needing to justify it.
- ◆ I'm learning to trust my discomfort as useful data, not weakness.
- ◆ I check in with myself before asking others what they think.
- ◆ I'm less afraid of being disliked when I honour my needs.
- ◆ I've started to feel anger as protective, not shameful.
- ◆ I no longer feel the need to explain every boundary I set.
- ◆ I can sit with uncertainty without spiralling.
- ◆ I give weight to my instincts, even if they don't make logical sense yet.
- ◆ I know the difference between intuition and fear - and I listen accordingly.

Intuition & CPSTD - A Checklist

A checklist to develop your intuition.

Let your intuition speak.

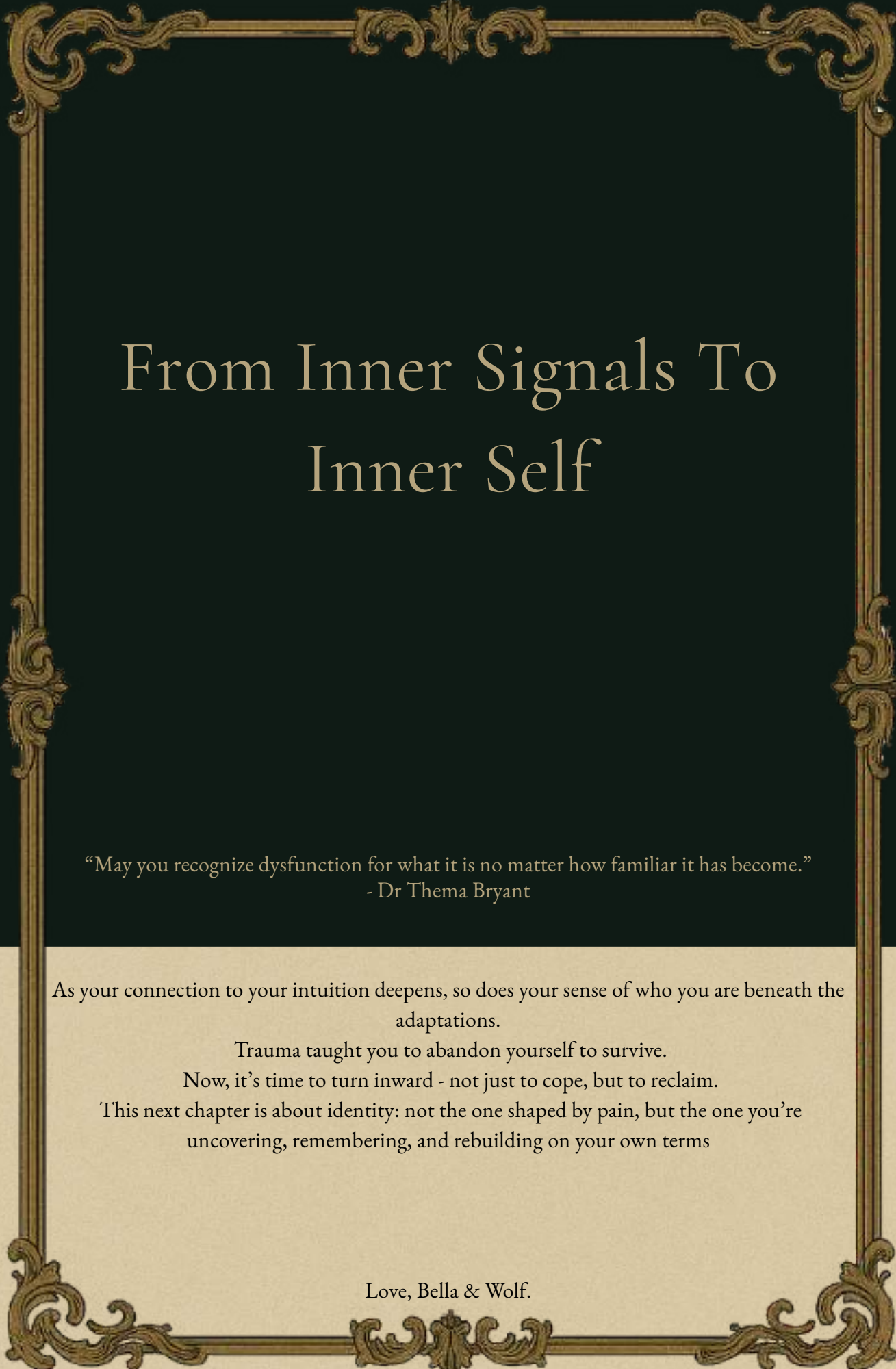
Skim the prompts. Stop at the one that hits. Write what comes up - no pressure, no overthinking.

Come back when you need clarity.

- ◆ What does your inner voice say when you consider this decision or situation?
- ◆ If you did know the answer deep down, what would it be?
- ◆ Do you have a hunch or sense of knowing, even without evidence?
- ◆ What's the first answer that popped into your head before overthinking?
- ◆ Where in your body do you feel a response to this situation?
- ◆ What was your gut reaction - without analysis?
- ◆ If your body could vote, what would it choose?
- ◆ Has you thought about it longer than 24 hours? if so follow it up
- ◆ Does this situation remind you of anything or anyone from your past?
- ◆ Are there emotions that seem louder than the situation warrants?
- ◆ Which choice aligns most with your core values and long-term vision?
- ◆ If there were no consequences, judgement, or pressure - what would you do?
- ◆ How do you feel emotionally when you sit with each potential choice?
- ◆ Which option makes you feel most like your authentic self?
- ◆ What outcome brings a sense of peace, even if it's not the easiest?
- ◆ What would you tell a friend in your situation?
- ◆ What would your future self want you to choose?
- ◆ What would the most self-compassionate version of you decide?
- ◆ Does this feel like a trauma response or a grounded decision?
- ◆ Are you trying to convince yourself of something that doesn't feel right?
- ◆ What fear is influencing your thinking - and what would be true without it?
- ◆ Are you choosing based on survival or expansion?
- ◆ If you could pause time and listen to the quiet beneath the noise, what answer is already waiting for you?
- ◆ What part of you is speaking loudest right now?
Fear, hope, old wounds, wisdom? Who do you want to give the mic to?
- ◆ Does this choice pull you toward yourself, or away from who you're becoming?
- ◆ When you imagine each path unfolding, which one feels like relief?

Intuition & CPSTD

A large, blank, lined page from a notebook. The page is cream-colored with horizontal ruling lines. The corners are rounded. The page is intended for writing.



From Inner Signals To Inner Self

“May you recognize dysfunction for what it is no matter how familiar it has become.”
- Dr Thema Bryant

As your connection to your intuition deepens, so does your sense of who you are beneath the adaptations.

Trauma taught you to abandon yourself to survive.

Now, it's time to turn inward - not just to cope, but to reclaim.

This next chapter is about identity: not the one shaped by pain, but the one you're uncovering, remembering, and rebuilding on your own terms

Love, Bella & Wolf.

Reclaiming Identity After Trauma

From Reaction to Reconstruction

Who am I without the trauma?

You've just explored how trauma shapes your inner world - the way your body tightens, your mind races, your emotions flare or fade. When life becomes a loop of reacting to threat, identity isn't something you grow - it's something you armour.

For many survivors, trauma didn't just interrupt life. It rewired it.

You became who you needed to be to get through - hyper-independent, overly pleasing, quick to withdraw, always scanning for danger.

These weren't flaws. They were survival skills.

But now, something's shifting. Maybe a part of you is whispering: "I want more than this."

Not just safety, but wholeness.

Not just surviving, but living.

This work isn't easy. Reclaiming identity after trauma means stepping into the unknown - not knowing exactly who you are yet, only who you are not.

It means grieving who you didn't get to be, and creating space for who you could become.

You don't have to have the answers yet.

This next chapter is about asking better questions.

Reclaiming Identity After Trauma

What do I love? What do I value? What feels true for me? What parts of me are still waiting to be seen?

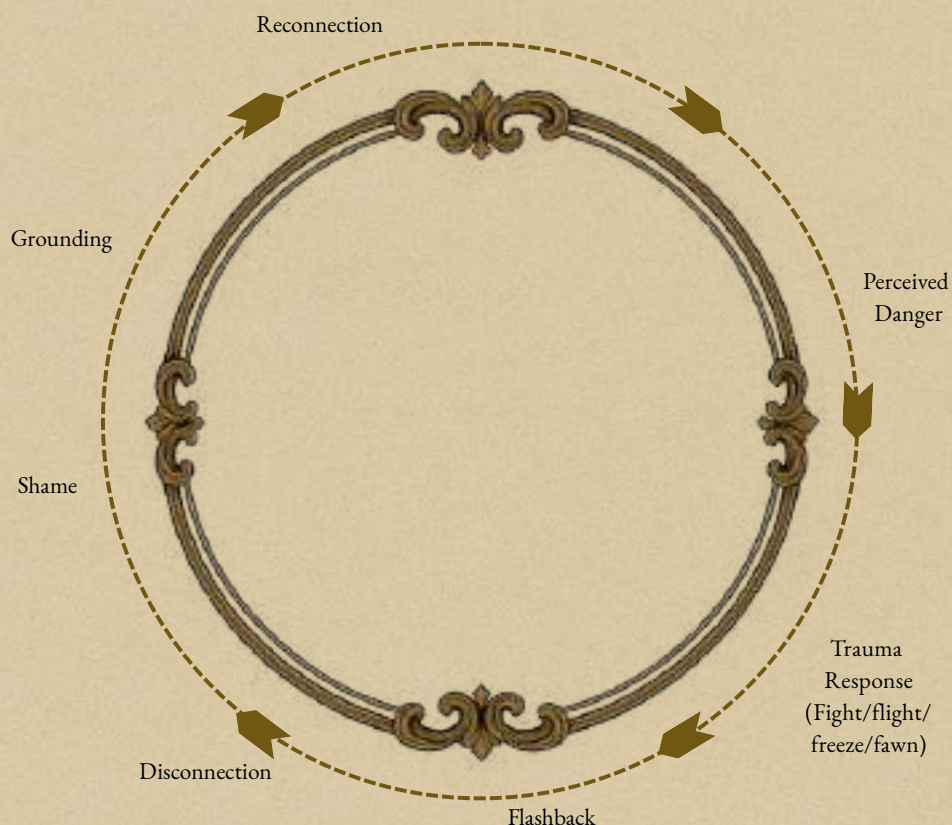
It's not about "going back" to some old version of yourself - It's about becoming someone new, someone whole, someone real. Someone who gets to choose.

If things feel messy or unfamiliar right now, you're not doing it wrong. That's what rebuilding from the inside out looks like.

Before we go further, you may want to revisit the Central Cycle diagram below. It's useful to remember how survival patterns ripple outward - and how identity can be shaped, limited, or fractured by those patterns.

This chapter isn't about fixing yourself.

It's about finding yourself - underneath everything you had to become to survive.



Reclaiming Identity After Trauma

Trauma often strips us of our sense of self. It erodes the parts of us that once felt certain- our confidence, our voice, our preferences.

Reclaiming identity isn't about 'going back' to who you were. It's about rediscovering who you are now, rebuilding with awareness, compassion, and choice.

The Fragmented Self

Identity isn't fixed - it's formed through experience, relationships, and environment. It's how we answer the question: "Who am I?" But when trauma enters early or often - particularly adverse childhood experiences (ACEs) or prolonged exposure to unsafe environments - that sense of self doesn't just get shaken. It gets splintered.

Trauma's Impact on the Developing Psyche

In childhood, the brain is still building internal structures that form a stable identity. Things like:

- ◆ Emotional regulation
- ◆ Boundaries and agency
- ◆ Trust in the self and others
- ◆ A coherent life narrative

Trauma interrupts this construction.

When survival takes priority, the brain doesn't get to build long-term coherence. Instead, it builds defence mechanisms: dissociation, fawning, emotional suppression, hypervigilance.

Over time, these become parts of the self - but they were built for protection, not authenticity.

This leads to:

- ◆ Fragmented identity - feeling like "different versions" of yourself in different contexts
- ◆ Chronic shame or self-loathing - especially when trauma responses clash with values (Egodystonic)
- ◆ Loss of agency - life is something that happens to you, not something you shape
- ◆ Disconnection from joy, interests, personality - you forget what you liked, who you were

Reclaiming Identity After Trauma: The Fragmented Self

Reclaiming the Self

◆ Step 1: Meet the Fragmented Self

Label each shard, write a word that reflects how trauma left its mark - labels you carried, roles you survived through, or feelings you buried.

Examples: Numb/ Angry / Invisible
Too much/ Too quiet/ Broken/ Hyper-independent /
People pleaser.

These are not flaws - they're survival responses.



◆ Step 2: Rebuild with Intention Next to it, create a mosaic.

In each piece, rewrite those parts as strengths, reclaimed truths, or evolved identities.

Examples: Aware/Protective/Healing/Enough
Grounded/Assertive/ Loved /Worthy

What did this part protect you from?
What strength was buried underneath this survival
mode?

Who are you choosing to become now?

Reclaiming Identity After Trauma

“Who am I without the trauma?”

Trauma doesn't just hurt you - it rewrites you.

Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs) don't just leave emotional bruises. They rewire your nervous system for survival. When you grow up in chaos, neglect, or threat, your brain learns to adapt - not thrive. You shape yourself around danger. You lose access to who you might've been.

So you become:

- ◆ The Helper - always needed, never needing
- ◆ The Perfectionist - flawless on the outside, frantic underneath
- ◆ The Invisible One - quiet, compliant, untouchable
- ◆ The Tough One - armoured, sarcastic, never caught slipping

These weren't flaws. They were strategies. Intelligent, protective, life-saving.

But now? They're costing you your self.

The Long-Term Trade-Off

Trauma doesn't just pass with time. It embeds itself into how you see yourself - and how you don't.

You might find it hard to:

- ◆ Know what you want - because your wants weren't safe
- ◆ Feel emotions - because emotional safety never existed
- ◆ Set boundaries - because they were ignored or punished
- ◆ Recognise yourself - because you built a life around surviving, not living

This isn't brokenness. It's a normal response to abnormal conditions.

Reclaiming Identity After Trauma

The “Adapted Self”

The Adapted Self isn't false. It's forged. It tells the story of what you survived. You didn't choose to be like this. You became this to stay safe. Healing doesn't mean erasing it.

It means understanding it:

- ◆ Why it formed.
- ◆ What it protected you from.
- ◆ What it still believes.
- ◆ And whether those beliefs are still true.
- ◆ Rebuilding the real you.
- ◆ Reclaiming identity isn't a one-time act.

It's a slow, sacred process.

It looks like:

- ◆ Meeting your fragmented parts with compassion.
- ◆ Naming the roles you were forced into.
- ◆ Listening to their stories.

Choosing something different, now that you can.

Because here's the truth:

- ◆ You are not the role.
- ◆ You are not the reaction.
- ◆ You are not the fear.

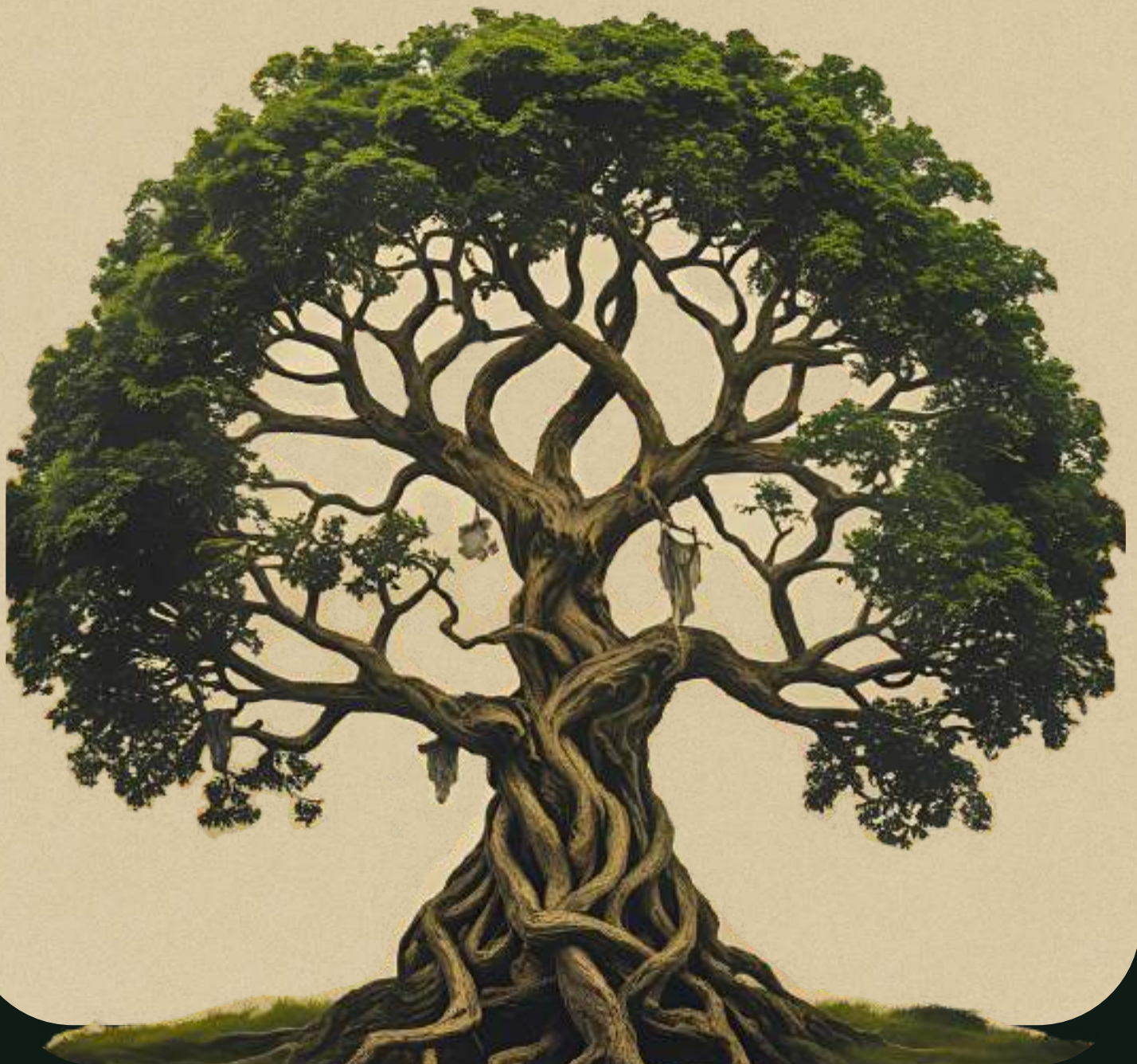
You are the one underneath it all - still here, still waiting, still becoming.

Reclaiming Identity After Trauma: Who am I?

How to:

Use the tree below to draw how you see yourself, think: Centre = Self.

Petals/leaves = roles, values, likes, beliefs, quirks, cultural identity. Create a “before trauma / now / in recovery” version to compare.



Attachments, Relationships & Boundaries

Haunted connections, hidden patterns, and the long road to safety

Trauma doesn't just wound the self - it warps how we connect with others. Especially if the trauma came from those who were meant to love or protect you.

If your early attachments were marked by fear, inconsistency, or neglect, your nervous system learned to survive relationships, not thrive in them.

Safety became conditional. Love became something to earn, chase, or distrust. Boundaries were blurred, ignored, or punished.

So now, relationships might feel like:

- ◆ A performance. You shape-shift to keep the peace.
- ◆ A battlefield. Connection triggers panic, control, or shutdown.
- ◆ A mystery. You can't tell what's healthy vs. familiar.
- ◆ A loss of self. You disappear into someone else's needs.

These are not flaws.

They're echoes of attachment systems built under pressure.

Trauma-Taught Attachment Styles

Without secure, attuned caregiving, your nervous system may default to:

- ◆ Anxious attachment: You fear abandonment, overgive, and struggle with self-worth.
- ◆ Avoidant attachment: You suppress needs, distrust closeness, and keep people at arm's length.
- ◆ Disorganised attachment: You crave connection and fear it at the same time. Intimacy feels both vital and dangerous.

Your patterns aren't random. They're adaptations - built to navigate unsafe bonds.

Attachments, Relationships & Boundaries

Boundaries: A Forgotten Language

If you were never allowed to say no, or punished for having needs, boundaries may now feel:

- ◆ Dangerous
- ◆ “Mean”
- ◆ Like rejection
- ◆ Or completely foreign

But boundaries aren't walls. They're doors.

They help you decide what to let in and what to keep out. They protect not just your energy, but your emerging self, the parts of you that have been hidden, silenced, or denied.

Boundaries are also a form of self-expression. They tell the world who you are, what you need, and how you want to be treated. Learning them can feel uncomfortable or even guilt-inducing at first, because it's unfamiliar. But each time you assert a boundary, you're teaching yourself and others how to show up for you.

Why This Work Matters

Reclaiming how you attach, relate, and protect yourself isn't about being “better” at relationships. It's about re-learning how to be safe with others without abandoning yourself.

It might mean:

- ◆ Noticing when a trauma bond is masquerading as love
- ◆ Sitting with guilt after setting a boundary
- ◆ Letting someone really see you, even when it terrifies you
- ◆ Choosing people who honour your healing instead of repeating your hurt
- ◆ It's tender work. Messy work. Necessary work.

Because healthy connection isn't just possible - it's your birthright.

From Connection to Cognition

“Your nervous system isn’t overreacting. It’s remembering.”

-Unknown

The ways we connect in early life leave deep marks on how our minds work today. These early relationships don’t just shape our feelings - they program patterns of thought and behaviour that often run beneath our awareness.

When attachments are unsafe or inconsistent, our brains learn to scan for danger, blame ourselves, and brace for rejection. This chapter invites you to explore those hidden scripts - those automatic reactions like spiralling thoughts, shutting down, or feeling misunderstood. You’ll gain insight into how these patterns developed, how they show up now, and how you can begin to gently pause them, responding with awareness and self-compassion rather than autopilot fear.

In the pages ahead, you’ll discover:

How attachment imprints influence your daily thinking and emotions

The cycle of overthinking, emotional shutdown, and protective scripts

Ways to identify and interrupt these automatic patterns

Practical tools to foster awareness and self-kindness

Love, Bella & Wolf

Thoughts, Feelings, Actions: The Web We Weave

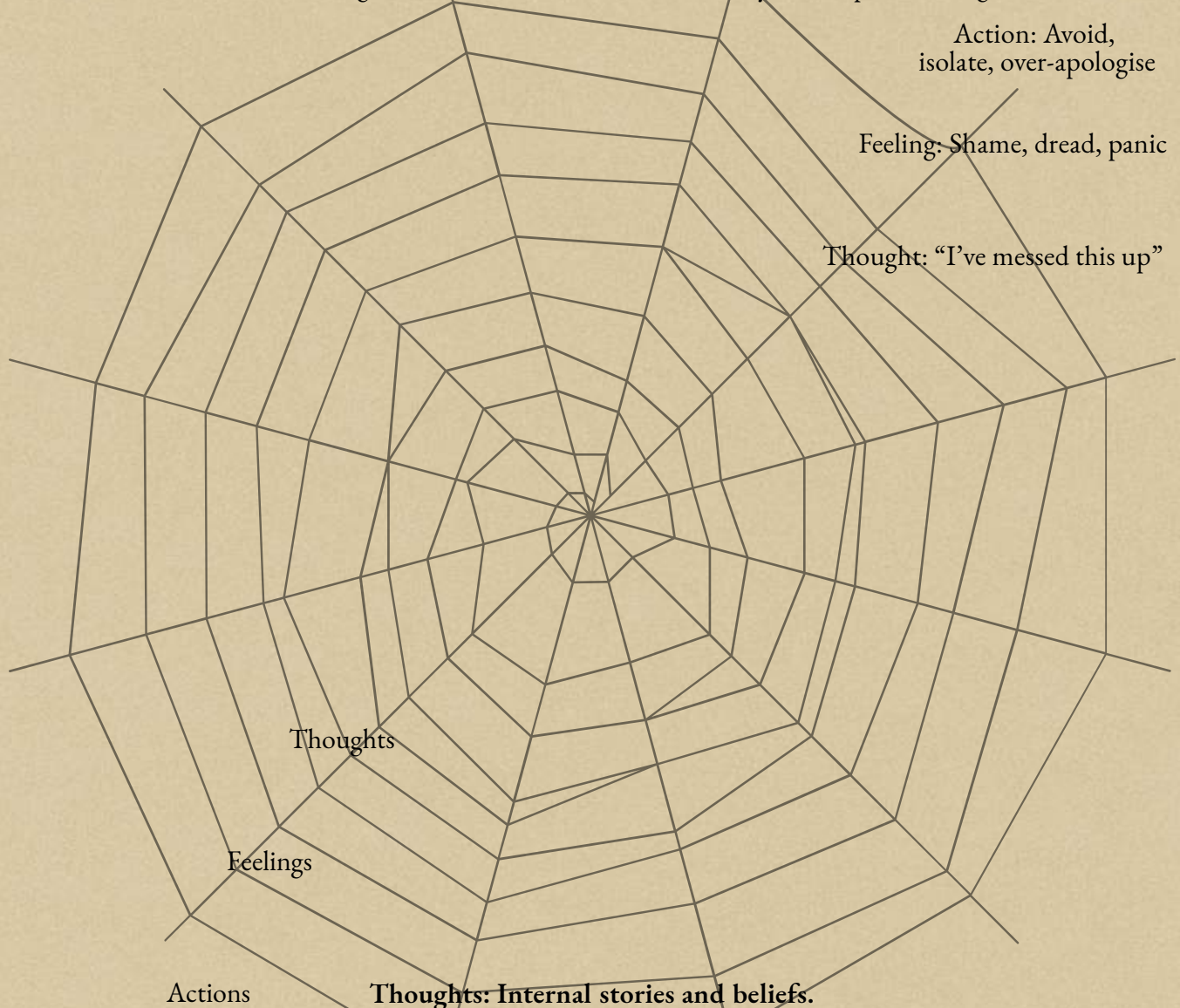
The mind weaves a web. Tug one thread, and the whole shudders.

Everything you do, say, or feel begins with a thought.

That thought stirs emotion. The emotion sparks action.

When you've survived trauma, this cycle often runs on autopilot - reactive, fast, and ghosted by your past.

It can feel like the feeling came first - but beneath it was always a whisper of thought.



Often harsh, rigid, catastrophic after trauma. Feelings: Emotional + physical responses. E.g., dread, heat in chest, numbness. Actions: What you do or avoid. Patterns may echo your survival roles (people-pleasing, withdrawal, control).

Left unchecked, the cycle feeds itself.

Thought → Feeling → Action → Consequence → Reinforced Thought

The web tightens. The belief grows stronger. But just as it was woven, it can be unspun.

Ant's on a path:

Automatic Negative Thoughts

What you'll need:

- ◆ Space on the next page(s)/ blank page
- ◆ Pens or pencils
- ◆ A ruler or straight edge (optional)

Instructions:

- ◆ Draw a few small ants (or tiny scribbles/doodles) randomly scattered across the page. These represent Automatic Negative Thoughts (ANTs) - intrusive thoughts that appear without conscious control.
- ◆ Pick a starting point and draw a straight line across the page. This represents your intended path or day.
- ◆ Every time your line reaches an ant, draw around it, curving or weaving around the obstacle. Don't erase it, don't power through it - acknowledge it and adapt.
- ◆ At the end, observe the line. Notice how the path changed because of these small disruptions.

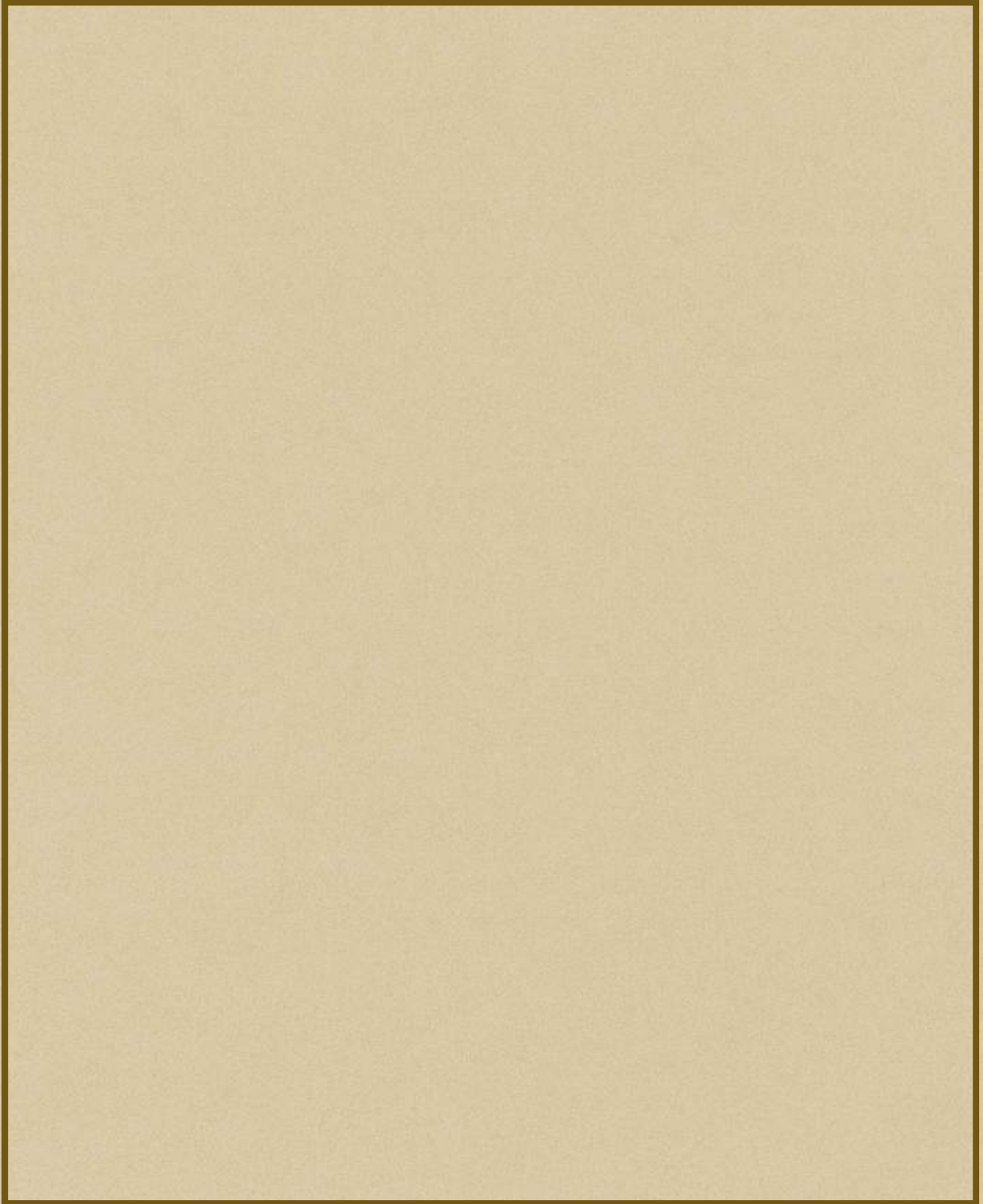
Then reflect:

- ◆ What did the ants represent?
- ◆ How often do small thoughts shift your whole day or decision?
- ◆ Can the line still reach the other side?
- ◆ What would it take to shift or shrink an ANT?

Why this matters:

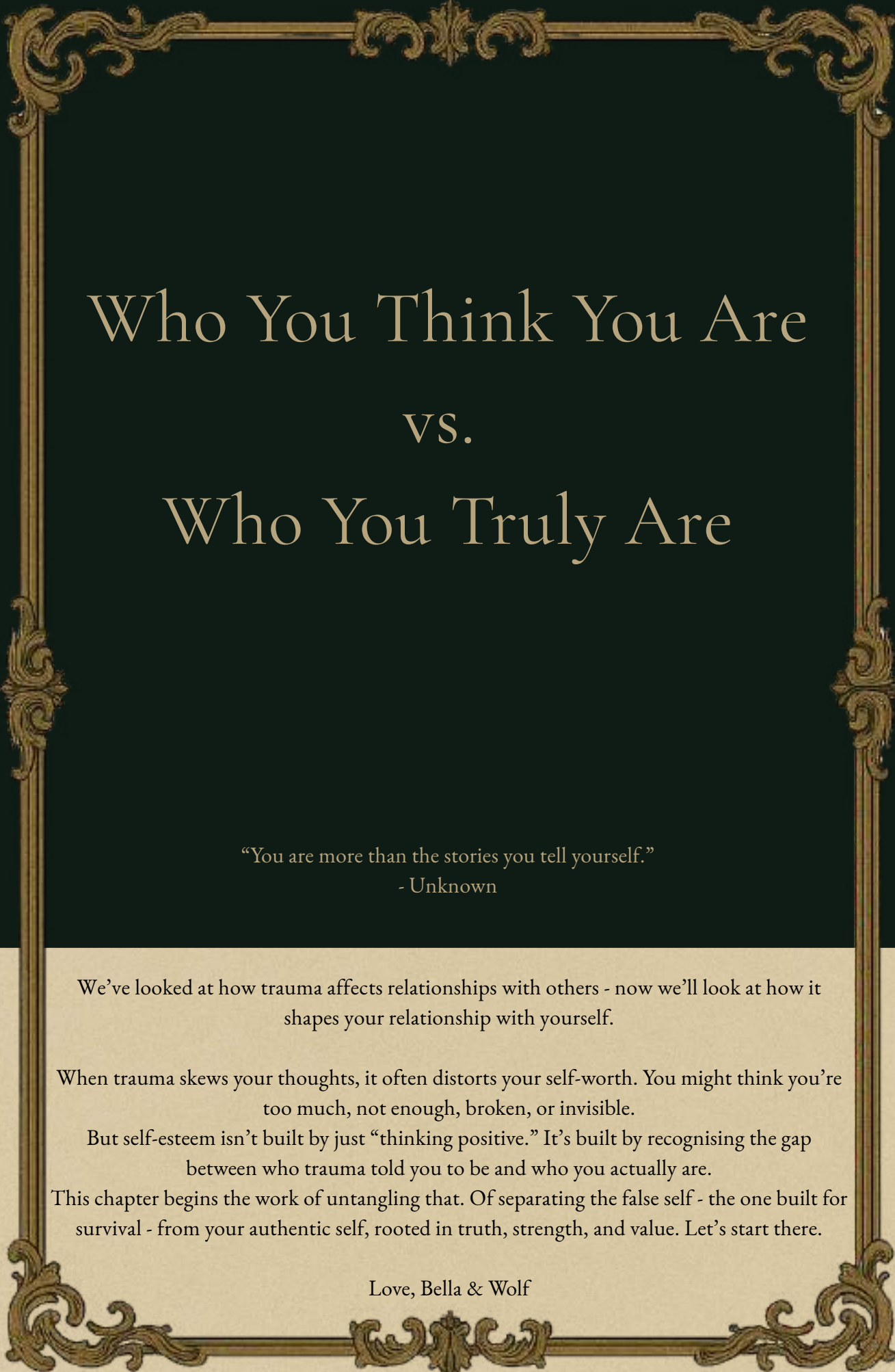
Automatic Negative Thoughts are quick, convincing, and often invisible until they've redirected us. This exercise gives them form, so you can see how they subtly pull you off course. The goal isn't to force them away, but to notice your capacity to adapt and stay connected to your path, even when your mind throws distractions in the way.

Ant's on a path: Automatic Negative Thoughts

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, intended for writing or drawing. The box is centered on the page and occupies most of the lower half of the page.

Ant's on a path: Reflections

A large, blank, lined page from a notebook, intended for reflections. The page is cream-colored with horizontal ruling lines. The corners are rounded. The page is set against a dark background.



Who You Think You Are vs. Who You Truly Are

“You are more than the stories you tell yourself.”
- Unknown

We’ve looked at how trauma affects relationships with others - now we’ll look at how it shapes your relationship with yourself.

When trauma skews your thoughts, it often distorts your self-worth. You might think you’re too much, not enough, broken, or invisible.

But self-esteem isn’t built by just “thinking positive.” It’s built by recognising the gap between who trauma told you to be and who you actually are.

This chapter begins the work of untangling that. Of separating the false self - the one built for survival - from your authentic self, rooted in truth, strength, and value. Let’s start there.

Love, Bella & Wolf

Who You Think You Are vs. Who You Truly Are

Between Thought and Identity

Our sense of identity is built from thousands of small signals - thoughts, emotions, body sensations, and the reactions we get from others. Over time, the brain weaves those signals into a coherent story: "This is who I am."

For people with complex trauma, that story forms in an environment where safety, validation, or consistency were missing. The nervous system adapts - not to thrive, but to survive. It learns that belonging might depend on suppressing feelings, performing for approval, or predicting danger before it happens.

Neuroscience helps explain why this happens, when the limbic system is overactivated for long periods, the brain becomes wired for protection. The amygdala keeps scanning for threat, the prefrontal cortex (responsible for reflection and emotional regulation) struggles to stay online, and the hippocampus can have difficulty organising memories into a clear timeline. The result: you don't just remember unsafe experiences - you start to become them. Your body and thoughts interpret the world through the lens of "I am unsafe," even when the danger has passed.

In psychology, this process is called internalisation - the tendency to absorb repeated external messages ("You're too much," "You're not enough") and turn them into self-beliefs. Because trauma happens in relationship, those beliefs get wired in at the deepest level of self-concept. What begins as a survival strategy such as staying quiet, overachieving, pleasing others, gradually forms a false self: a version of you that maintains connection at the cost of authenticity.

This isn't a character flaw. It's neuroplasticity doing its job - reshaping your brain to meet the demands of an unsafe environment. But once the threat is gone, that wiring doesn't automatically reset. The same neural pathways that protected you can now keep you trapped in self-doubt, guilt, or over-responsibility.

Healing means recognising this pattern for what it is: an adaptation, not a definition. The authentic self isn't something you have to invent - it's what remains when the survival self no longer has to run the show.

Self-Esteem After CPTSD

CPTSD doesn't just damage self-esteem - it rewires it.

You weren't born doubting yourself. That was taught through chronic invalidation, shame, abuse, or neglect.

Your sense of worth got shaped by survival, not truth.

False VS Authentic Self-Esteem

False (Trauma built)	Authentic (Healing built)
Comes from pleasing others	Comes from inner truth
Based on performance/achievements	Based on inherent worth
Fear of being "too much" or "not enough"	Acceptance of your full self
Fragile, reliant on external validation	Grounded, internal anchor
Guilt for having needs	Needs are human, not selfish
People pleasing = survival	Boundaries = safety

The Mirror of Values

- ◆ On one side of a page, draw a simple stick figure of someone you admire. It can be anyone: a friend, a public figure, a character, someone who's passed, even a pet.
- ◆ Around that figure, list qualities you respect in them. Examples: "They speak their mind." "They are calm in chaos." "They protect others." "They are kind, even when angry."
- ◆ On the other side of the page, draw yourself as a stick figure.
- ◆ Reflect and write what you share with the person you admire. Don't force it - but be curious. Are the things you admire actually traits you value deeply, and maybe show in your own way?

Them

Me

Reflections

Love, Bella & Wolf

Finding Support That Meets You Where You Are

“The right support doesn’t rush you or judge you. It simply meets you exactly where you are and walks alongside you.”

- Kimberley Hajee

As you reconnect with your values and identity, it’s normal to want something more - a structured path, deeper healing, support that’s attuned to the depth of your experiences.

This next chapter shares one of those paths: EMDR (Eye Movement Desensitisation and Reprocessing).

Not every therapy works for everyone, but hearing about what helped others can spark insight into what might work for you.

This is not a recommendation - it’s a reflection. One part of the journey that supported me, which you might explore in your own way.

Love, Bella & Wolf

EMDR:

What Helped Me Heal

Flickers of Healing

Healing didn't come like a lightning bolt. It came in flickers - quiet moments in a dark room, a breath I hadn't realised I was holding, a shift I couldn't name until I noticed I'd stopped bracing.

EMDR didn't erase what happened, it didn't make the past disappear. It helped me remember without reliving. It helped my body feel what my mind had locked away. And in doing so, it gave me something I hadn't had in years: choice, space, and a nervous system that wasn't constantly preparing for war.

For as long as I can remember, books were a refuge, a doorway to a world that wasn't mine, a fantasy I could live when my own felt unsafe. They were a reprieve from nightmares that haunted sleep, a distraction when the dark closed in. Through stories, I lived as if I were another - someone brave, free, protected.

EMDR helped me find things I didn't know were lost. I thought I knew what I was healing from, but it took me deeper, past the obvious wounds, past the stories I'd repeated in therapy before, into the roots I didn't even know were choking me.

One of the biggest? A fear of failure which was buried so deep it shaped everything I did. It was woven into my identity so tightly that I hadn't even questioned it. I'd just adapted around it: avoiding risk, shrinking dreams, talking myself out of the things I wanted most.

Then one day, mid-recovery, mid-mess, I caught myself making a recipe I'd always wanted to try. Something I used to say was, "I'm not good enough for..." or "What if I mess it up?" But I was doing it. No drama. No fanfare. Just... making the thing. And that's when it hit me: the fear wasn't driving anymore.

Hidden Milestones

For me, EMDR was the support I didn't know I needed. But so were moments I almost didn't notice: a therapist who checked in even when I said nothing, friends who let me vent without fixing, a safe corner with a book that let me breathe. Support came in forms I couldn't have scripted, and in that, I learned something vital: healing isn't linear. The right support adapts to the rhythm of your recovery, not the calendar of someone else's expectations.

Healing often shows up in ways you'd never expect, and some of the things I hadn't noticed were actually tied to trauma and PTSD. For years, I couldn't have a coffee or even an energy drink, my body would spike with panic - heart racing, breath shallow -, this often led to full blown panic attacks so I avoided it completely.

Then, as I worked through EMDR and started addressing the underlying trauma, I began to notice shifts. One day, I had a Red Bull. Just one. And it felt incredible. To someone else, it might seem trivial or even bizarre, but for me, it was a milestone. I felt cool. I felt unstoppable. I celebrated that little win.

EMDR:

What Helped Me Heal

Other “small” things became milestones too. I could walk up the stairs without the fear that moving too fast would trigger a racing heart and panic attack. I could run, race my younger sister, play in the park - things I’d wanted to do for years but avoided out of fear. Each of these moments was a quiet declaration: my body didn’t have to live in constant alarm anymore.

Recovery isn’t always dramatic. Sometimes it’s these tiny, personal victories that mark the real progress. Learning to notice them, celebrate them, and own them is part of reclaiming your life from trauma.

Meeting Your Younger Self

One session brought a memory of my younger self - small, scared, alone. I stood with her, helpless at first, looking through a half-built brick wall. Beyond it lay warmth, sunlight, birdsong, but we were in shadows, cold and dark.

Then something shifted, I looked down and saw her curled on the floor. I took her hand, and the image changed. Suddenly, I was her protector, her guardian. My hair braided, broadsword strapped across my back and ready for war, ready to shield her, ready to shield me.

Another time, stuck deep in a memory I couldn’t escape, my mind showed me flashes - images from past sessions - me comforting that younger self, the parts left behind, like ghosts of Christmas Past almost. So many versions of me, fractured but still standing, each surviving in their own way. One by one, I held them. Told them it was okay. That they were safe. And slowly, “You are safe” became “I am safe.”

It Wasn’t Linear

Some sessions were short. Some cracked me open.

I’d leave feeling lighter, or heavier, or confused.

Progress didn’t always look like healing. Sometimes it looked like collapsing in bed and needing the whole day to come back into my body.

But slowly, the charge faded.

I started remembering things without being hijacked by them.

I stopped avoiding the places where my pain used to live.

I saw what I’d done to survive.

And then I saw what I could do to live.

EMDR:

What Helped Me Heal

What Helped Me Most

A therapist who held the space - not perfectly, but steadily.

Pausing when I needed to, no matter how long it took.

Letting silence be part of the process.

Bringing grounding tools (For me it was my water bottle but it could be a smell or texture or snack)

Journaling, resting or painting after sessions.

Accepting that the work continues outside the therapy room.

What I'd Tell You Now

You don't have to force anything.

Your system knows what to bring up, and when.

If you feel like nothing's changing - watch again.

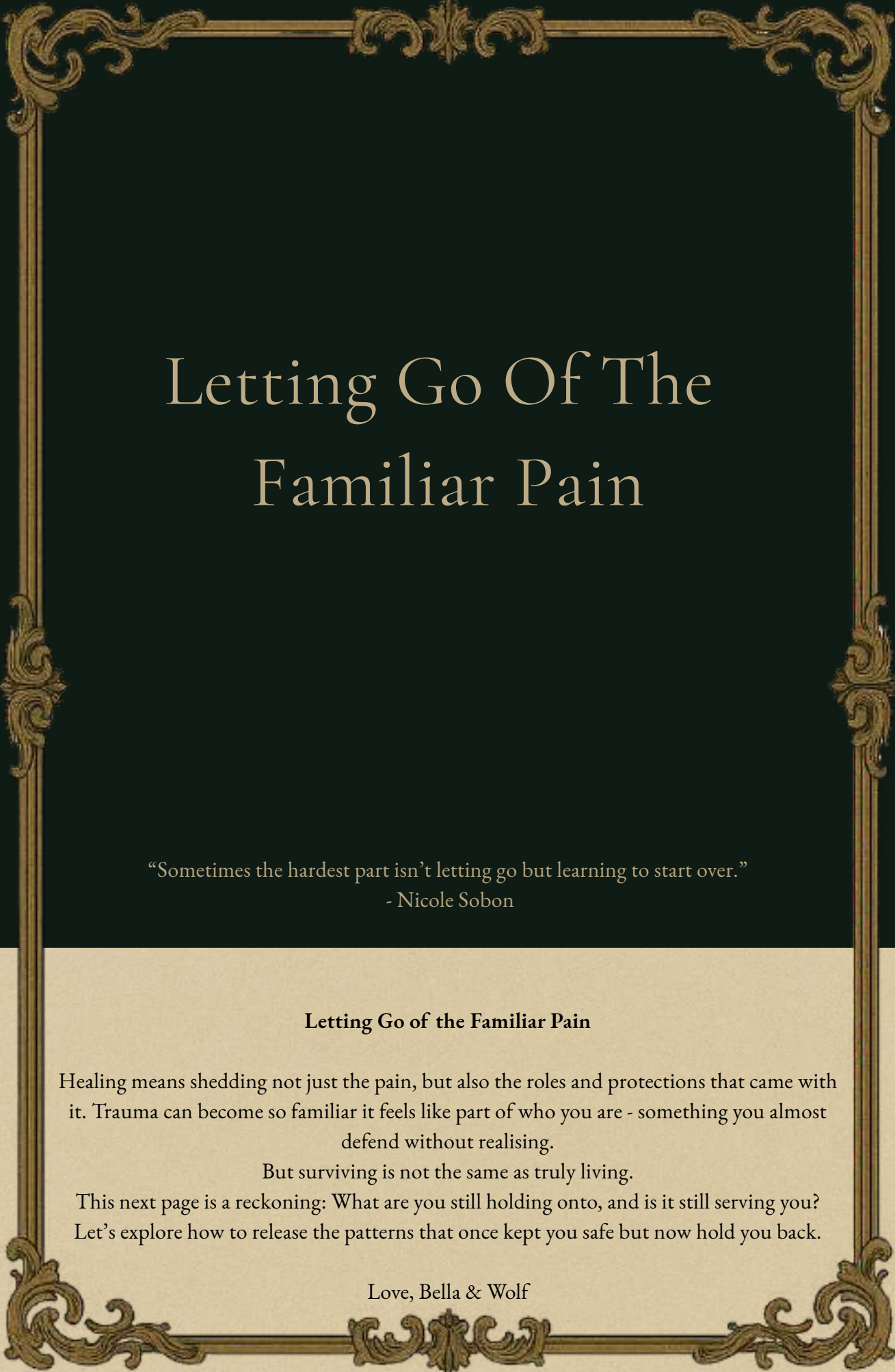
You might find yourself doing something you'd always avoided.

You might feel a little less afraid. A little more real.

That is healing. That is movement.

And one day, you might hear your own voice say it clearly:

"It's okay. I am safe"



Letting Go Of The Familiar Pain

“Sometimes the hardest part isn’t letting go but learning to start over.”
- Nicole Sobon

Letting Go of the Familiar Pain

Healing means shedding not just the pain, but also the roles and protections that came with it. Trauma can become so familiar it feels like part of who you are - something you almost defend without realising.

But surviving is not the same as truly living.

This next page is a reckoning: What are you still holding onto, and is it still serving you? Let’s explore how to release the patterns that once kept you safe but now hold you back.

Love, Bella & Wolf

Why CPTSD Is No Longer Your Friend

CPTSD showed up to protect you when life was unsafe.

It became your survival system, your constant, unwelcome companion.

It sharpened your senses, kept you alert, and helped you manage chaos.

It scanned every room, every tone, every silence. It learned to predict danger before it arrived.

In that way, it was useful. It kept you alive. But survival has an expiry date.

When life becomes safer, those same defences turn against you, the hypervigilance that once saved you now leaves you wired and exhausted, the self-blame that kept you in control now keeps you small, the walls that once protected you now keep love, joy, and trust on the outside.

CPTSD isn't your ally anymore.

It traps you in loops of fear, shame, and disconnection, it steals your energy, your peace, and your sense of self and it whispers lies like "You're broken" or "You can't trust yourself."

These messages keep you stuck, exhausted, and isolated. But here's the truth: you don't need them anymore. Your nervous system doesn't need to be on guard to keep you safe and you don't have to earn rest, or love, or belonging.

It's time to see CPTSD for what it really is - a defence that outlived its use.

You get to thank it for what it did, and then begin the work of gently letting it go.

CPTSD may have been your bodyguard, but it's no longer the friend you need.

Reflection: Meeting Your Former Protector

Take a moment to notice your body. Where do you feel tension, alertness, or heaviness?

Imagine your CPTSD patterns as a companion standing nearby - protective, but no longer needed.

Ask yourself, gently:

- ◆ What am I still holding onto that once kept me safe?
- ◆ Which of these patterns no longer serves me?
- ◆ What small ways could I allow myself to release them, even just a little today?

Take a slow breath. Visualise letting go of one small piece - a fear, a worry, a habit - without judgement. Notice how your body responds.

When you're ready, jot down any thoughts or sensations. These aren't tasks or goals - they're signals from your body and mind showing you what's shifting.

Why CPTSD Is No Longer Your Friend : Reflections

A large, blank, lined page from a notebook, intended for reflections. The page is cream-colored with horizontal ruling lines. The corners of the page are rounded. The page is set against a dark background.

Making Safety Real

“Safety isn’t a place - it’s a feeling you learn to carry inside yourself.”
- Unknown

Letting go of trauma as part of your identity means creating something new to hold onto - not just the idea of safety, but a real, felt experience of it.
This chapter isn’t about perfection or control. It’s about carving out moments of safety you can return to — a place inside yourself and your environment where your nervous system can soften, even if only for a few breaths.
We’ll start small. We’ll build it together.

Love, Bella & Wolf

How to Build a Safe Space

Safety isn't always where you are - sometimes, it's what you create.

Use the following page(s) to design a space in your mind or life that makes you feel grounded, soothed, and in control.

This can be real, imagined, or somewhere in between. No rules, just your place.

◆ Visual (What do you see?)

☐ Light ☐ Dark ☐ Warm colours ☐ Cool tones ☐ Natural elements ☐ Familiar objects

◆ Touch / Feel (What textures or sensations surround you?)

☐ Soft blankets ☐ Warm sun ☐ Cool breeze ☐ Smooth stone ☐ Fuzzy jumper ☐ Bare skin
on grass

◆ Sound (What do you hear?)

☐ Silence ☐ Rainfall ☐ Music ☐ Wind in trees ☐ Crackling fire ☐ Ocean waves

◆ Scent (What's in the air?)

☐ Lavender ☐ Forest pine ☐ Vanilla ☐ Old books ☐ Clean sheets ☐ Earth after rain

◆ Taste (If anything)

☐ Hot tea ☐ Mint ☐ Comfort food ☐ Chocolate ☐ Fresh fruit ☐ Nothing — just calm

◆ Emotional Tone / Body Sense (How do you feel here? How does your body respond?)

☐ Calm ☐ Safe ☐ In control ☐ Protected ☐ Empowered ☐ Loved
☐ Light ☐ Grounded ☐ Relaxed ☐ Warm ☐ Tension-free ☐ Present

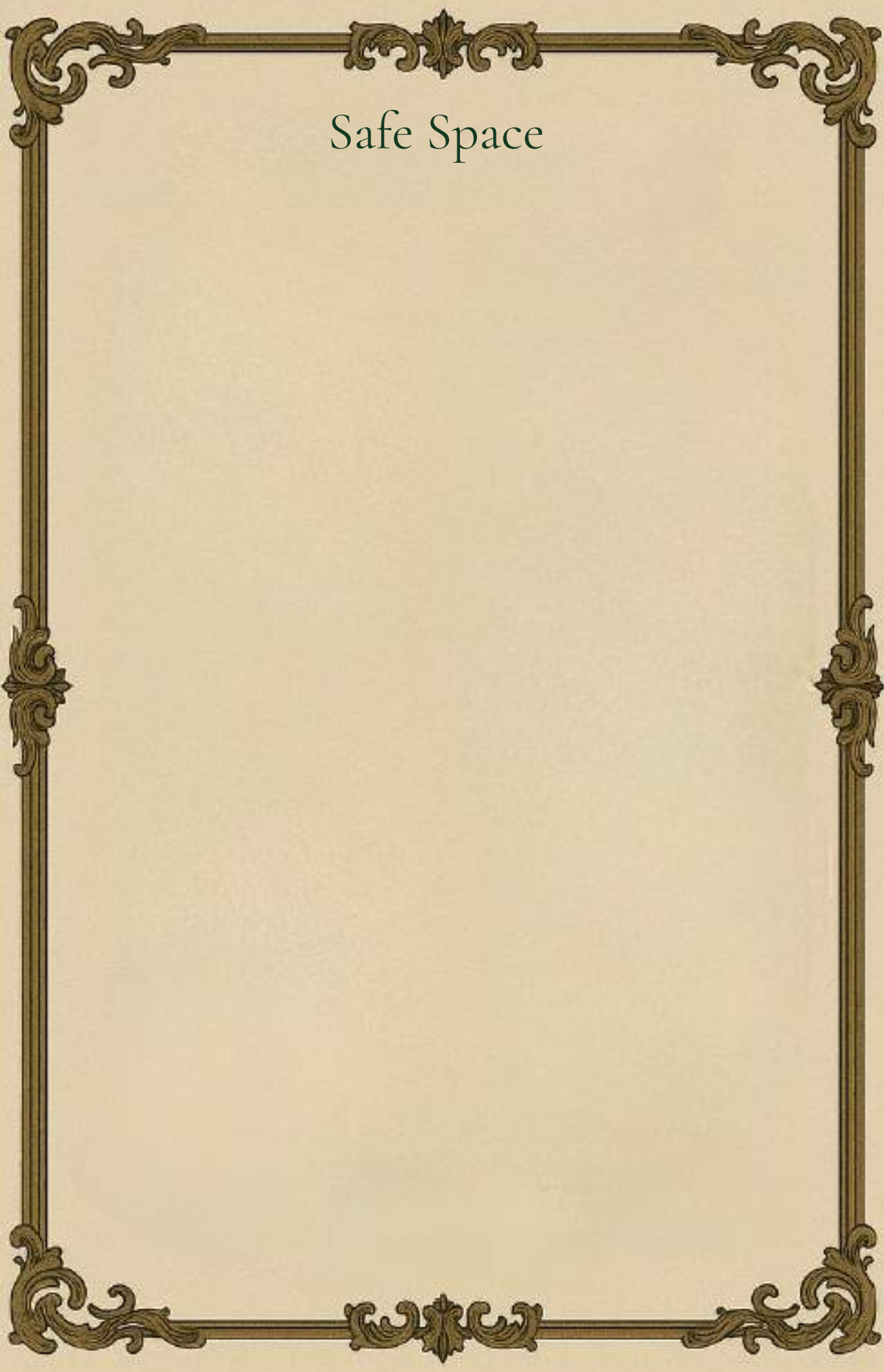
You built this with care, from shadow and from light.
A place to land. A place to breathe. A place to return to.
It doesn't have to be real to be powerful - only true to you.

Let it change. Let it expand. Let it protect.

Safe is not weak.

Safe is powerful.

You are home, even in yourself.



Safe Space

Tools for the Bad Days

“This too shall pass.”

- Persian Proverb

If you're here, it's because the weight of some days feels too much to carry - and that's nothing to be ashamed of. You are not broken for struggling. You are not weak for needing support. You are a warrior for surviving what you've survived, even when it doesn't feel like it. On the hardest days, the tools in this chapter are here to remind you that you are capable, that your feelings are valid, and that even the smallest steps can help you through the storm. And if there is one piece of advice I can offer you, survivor to survivor, it's this: you can get through this. Trust that your body is doing its best to protect you in the most basic, human way — and that together, we can make it through. You don't have to do everything. You don't have to get it perfect. You just have to keep going, one breath, one moment at a time. There's no pressure here — what helps one person might not work for another, and that's okay. Even the same tool might work one day and not the next. This is about building a toolkit that fits you and your needs, giving you options to reach for when you need them most.

Love, Bella & Wolf

5, 4, 3, 2, 1 Grounding

Purpose:

Anchor yourself in the present moment.

How to Use:

Find...

- ◆ 5 things you can see
- ◆ 4 things you can touch
- ◆ 3 things you can hear
- ◆ 2 things you can smell
- ◆ 1 thing you can taste

“I am here. I am safe. I can ride this wave.”

Love, Bella & Wolf

Box Breathing

(4-4-4-4)

Purpose:

Regulate nervous system & reduce anxiety.

How to Use:

- ◆ Inhale for 4 seconds
- ◆ Hold for 4 seconds
- ◆ Exhale for 4 seconds
- ◆ Hold for 4 seconds

Repeat 4 - 6 times. Do it slowly and intentionally.

Love, Bella & Wolf

Emergency Care Package

Purpose:

Sensory regulation for crisis days.

Create Your Own Basket:

Put it somewhere easily accessible.

Include items that help with:

- ◆ Visual → calming photos, favourite quotes, fairy lights
- ◆ Auditory → calming playlist, white noise, earplugs, headphones
- ◆ Tactile → soft blanket, fidget toy, textured stone, a old pet toy
- ◆ Smell → lavender oil, scented lotion, candle
 - ◆ Taste → mints, herbal tea, sour sweets
- ◆ Cognitive → affirmations, grounding scripts, therapy notes

Tip: Add a letter from your 'okay self' to your 'struggling self'.

Love, Bella & Wolf

The Balloon Release

Purpose:

Let go of stuck thoughts or feelings.

- ◆ Picture your thought as a balloon.
- ◆ Name the feeling or thought clearly: “This is fear I won’t be loved.”
- ◆ Imagine inflating the balloon with it.
- ◆ When you’re ready, watch it float away into the sky.
- ◆ Remind yourself: “I can let this go, even if just for now.”

Repeat as needed. It helps build detachment from intrusive thoughts.

Love, Bella & Wolf

What Would I Say To A Friend?

Purpose:

Reframe self-critical thoughts with compassion.

How to Use:

- ◆ When you're being hard on yourself, pause and ask: "If my friend felt this way, what would I say to them?"
- ◆ Now say that to yourself. Out loud if possible.

Love, Bella & Wolf

The Distress Tolerance Jar

Purpose:

Survive without acting on urges (harm, lashing out, withdrawing).

How to use:

- ◆ Fill a jar with ideas you've written on slips of paper.
- ◆ Pick one in a moment of crisis.

Example slips to include:

Cold water splash on face
run wrists under cold water for several minutes
scream into a pillow (you'll either laugh or cry)
Watch a funny video
Rip up paper while shouting
Count backwards from 100 in 3s
Smell something strong (citrus, peppermint)
Pet your dog/cat
Step outside for 2 mins
Do 10 jumping jacks / wall push-ups
Text a trusted person
Remind yourself: "This feeling is temporary."

Love, Bella & Wolf

“Safe Place” Visualisation

Purpose:

Create a mental refuge during high distress.

How to Use:

- ◆ Close your eyes and imagine a place where you feel completely safe...

- ◆ Engage all your senses:
What can you see? Hear? Smell? Feel?
Describe it in your mind.

- ◆ Visit this place whenever you feel overwhelmed.

It might help you to recall the image if you keep a physical reminder; a photo in your phone or bag, a piece of material that reminds you of it...

Love, Bella & Wolf

The “Factory Reset”

Steps

- ◆ Inhale deeply through the nose until your lungs feel full.
- ◆ Add a second, sharp “catch-up” inhale - a short, fast pull of air even though your lungs are already full. This is sometimes described as a “sniff” or “gulp” of air.
- ◆ Exhale fully through the mouth or nose, letting the body relax completely.
 - ◆ Optional cold stimulation: If safe, combine with holding cold water on your hands/face/neck - this enhances vagal activation.
- ◆ Repeat 2–3 times, pausing between rounds to notice sensations in your body.

Love, Bella & Wolf



“This Too Shall Pass” Card

When I feel...	I will try...

Love, Bella & Wolf

"This Too Shall Pass" Card

When I feel...	I will try...

Love, Bella & Wolf

Crisis Plan

When everything feels too much, this page holds you steady.

◆ What I'm Like When I'm in Crisis

Signs I'm not okay (thoughts, feelings, behaviours): _____

What others might notice about me:
My common triggers or situations that lead up to this: _____

My common triggers or situations that lead up to this: _____

◆ What Helps Me Feel Safe

Places that help me calm down: _____

What makes me feel safe (people, pets, Objects, sounds, or sensations that soothe me: _____

Words or phrases that bring comfort: _____

◆ Things That Make It Worse (Avoid These)

Actions that overwhelm me: _____

Things that others say or do that escalate my distress: _____

Environments or situations I should avoid in a crisis: _____

◆ Emergency Coping Tools

Grounding techniques that work for me (Music, media, or movement that soothes): _____

Mantras or coping statements ("This will pass," "I am safe now"): _____

Creative or distraction-based strategies: _____

◆ Crisis Contacts

Trusted personal contacts
(Name / Relationship / Phone): _____

Professionals or services:

GP / Therapist / Crisis Line: _____

What I might say when I can't explain how I feel: _____

◆ Aftercare & Recovery

How I can care for myself after the crisis: _____

Gentle routines to come back to (sleep, food, rest): _____

What I might need from others (support, space, reassurance): _____

Reminders of my strength, growth, and safety: _____

In moments of crisis, you don't need to fix everything. You just need to get through the next breath. One breath. Then the next.

Love, Bella & Wolf

Crisis Plan

When everything feels too much, this page holds you steady.

A blank, lined page with a decorative border. The page is cream-colored with horizontal lines and a dark brown, ornate border. The corners are rounded.A blank, lined page with a decorative border. The page is cream-colored with horizontal lines and a dark brown, ornate border. The corners are rounded.A blank, lined page with a decorative border. The page is cream-colored with horizontal lines and a dark brown, ornate border. The corners are rounded.A blank, lined page with a decorative border. The page is cream-colored with horizontal lines and a dark brown, ornate border. The corners are rounded.A blank, lined page with a decorative border. The page is cream-colored with horizontal lines and a dark brown, ornate border. The corners are rounded.A blank, lined page with a decorative border. The page is cream-colored with horizontal lines and a dark brown, ornate border. The corners are rounded.

In moments of crisis, you don't need to fix everything. You just need to get through the next breath. One breath. Then the next.

Love, Bella & Wolf

A Letter To The Tired, Trying & Dysregulated You

A large, blank, lined area for writing a letter, resembling a notebook page with rounded corners. The lines are horizontal and evenly spaced, providing a guide for handwriting. The background is a light beige color, contrasting with the dark background of the page.

Notes

A blank, lined page from a notebook. The page is cream-colored with rounded corners and features horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and extend across the width of the page, leaving a small margin at the top and bottom. The page is set against a dark background.

Final Words

“Even the darkest night will end and the sun will rise.”
- Victor Hugo

From the older sister who's been there.
You've wandered through shadowed woods and tangled thorns - the places trauma
carved deep, the places survival built its fortress.

This isn't a tidy ending, because healing rarely is. It's a crooked path lit by flickering
candles, where sometimes the night feels endless and sometimes the dawn peeks just
enough to promise you're still here.

Remember: this is only a chapter in a story you're still writing. You're not broken, not
lost, just beautifully unfinished - a dark rose blooming stubbornly in cracked stone.

Carry this with you: you are braver than the ghosts that haunt you, wiser than the
doubts that whisper, and more alive than the fears that bind.
And if ever you forget, come back here - to these pages, to yourself - where the older
sister waits, ready to remind you how fiercely you can love and survive.

Love, Bella & Wolf



